THE UNIVERSITY OF SYDNEY | Sydney Executive Plus+

The 2026

Skills Horizon

WHAT LEADERS NEED TO KNOW NEXT

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We recognise and pay respect to the Elders and communities—past and present—of the lands that the University of Sydney's campuses stand on. For thousands of years they have shared and exchanged knowledge across innumerable generations for the benefit of all.

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Our insights are yours

At the University of Sydney, we believe in leadership for good.

One quality of great leaders is generosity. Whether it's time, wisdom, or even a bowl of fries, sharing with your peers and your team is a surefire way to help them develop and succeed.

We came up with **Steal This Slide,** a quick and easy way for you to lift the insights from the 2026 Skills Horizon, in that same spirit of generosity. Whenever you see the **STEAL THIS** prompt, just scan the QR code and you'll get a downloadable version as a slide. You're welcome!

“Let’s hope that there are better ideas that come up and capture the imagination of people.”

Daniel Kahneman
Nobel Prize-winning economist

Executive overview

Welcome to the new edition of the Skills Horizon.

Let's start with a quick refresher. We created the Skills Horizon to help you navigate, lead, and succeed in a world that's become increasingly complex, uncertain, and messy—a period we refer to as "the decade of disorientation". But it's not all doom and gloom. To quote ourselves: "The next 10 years will be the most disorienting of your career. They could also become the most impactful."

When everything is constantly changing, it's difficult enough to sit with ambiguity, let alone commit to a course of action. As a leader, you have to do both. Curiosity and learning (or unlearning, in some cases) can help you gain a foothold and figure out a way forward. In this report, we explore the skills you need today, soon, and years from now, so you can stay ready for anything.

Enough preamble, we've got a lot to cover (it's true, the sequel is always bigger):

- First is an overview of how the world is changing, categorised into five Shifts: *The Values Shift, The Technology Shift, The Accountability Shift, The Trust Shift, and The Energy Shift*. Yes, these Shifts make our world messy, but they also hold new opportunities if you know how to interpret them properly.
- Then we introduce the four Clashes: *Policy vs People, Efficiency vs Expertise, Capability vs Control* and *Abundance vs Attention*. As things continue to shift, new, competing priorities emerge that you as a leader will need to reconcile. Despite the adversarial name, our quartet of Clashes aren't an either/or—you need both sides, so it's a case of how you'll strike a productive balance.
- From there we move into how we built the report. We read, we reviewed, we vigorously discussed. And we listened to a variety of influential voices. The report is filled with a dazzling array of insights and wisdom about our changing world, drawn from conversations with a global cast of more than 150 leaders, ranging from army generals to arts executives, CEOs to airline captains.
- After breaking down the many practical applications of the report—from using it to start sparkling dinner conversations to its role in bolstering your L&D strategy—we zoom in on the skills themselves and step through the three types of skills that stood out from our research *(Amplifiers, Movers, Unexpected Emergers)*.
- That's followed by Blobs, which represent the four, blob-shaped areas of skills convergence that will require your attention over the next decade: *Speaking the language of tech, Solving problems of scale, Working across difference, Thinking through complexity*. Don't let the cute name fool you—this section captures the shape of things to come.
- To close, we explore the traits and habits of *The Grounded Leader*, an archetype for leadership success in 2026 and beyond.

It's a disorienting and demanding time to be a leader. But if you stay open to learning new things, stability and clarity will often follow.

Happy upskilling!

"I cannot think of a more volatile, greater change in my career."

Vicki Brady
CEO, Telstra

"The very notion of volatility has become more volatile."

James Taylor
Managing Director, SBS

"The rate of change is so fast. It impacts resilience because it's hard to keep a team motivated and performing when things are constantly changing. The team needs resilience, individual team members need resilience and leaders need resilience. Building resilience around this pace of change is difficult."

Mel Silva
VP & MD, Google Australia & New Zealand

"Leaders will feel less solid ground underneath their feet. More is contestable, more is uncertain. You will need to think anew, in a fresh way, who your partners may need to be, what contribution you might need to make."

Professor Mark Scott AO
Vice-Chancellor and President,
The University of Sydney

"The age of deterministic outcomes has gone, and in its place, what's really needed, is an ability to think in a scenario fashion."

Carolyn Comer
Former President & CEO,
Shell Energy North America

"How do you deal with things like AI? As a senior leader in the organisation, you don't need to be an expert in everything. But you do need quite a broad foundation and understanding to be able to set policies, to understand what you do, but also what you don't do as an organisation."

Morten Wierod
CEO, ABB

"Leaders, particularly in larger companies, need to cultivate the emotional intelligence to deal with the immense complexity of the evolving social psyche."

Robert Thomson
Chief Executive,
News Corp

"Business needs to lean into the political and the policy formation process a bit more."

Mark Rigotti
MD & CEO, AICD

"I'm unlearning all the time. Because I believe that you've got to ask yourself every day, whether the way we're doing things today is still the best, most effective, creative, interesting way to do it. The best way to keep yourself interested and relevant and productive is to always be prepared to look at the new way of doing something."

The Hon. Malcolm Turnbull AC
29th Prime Minister of Australia

"You saw me say on stage that I was wrong. Leaders need to have confident humility. The world is moving so fast. As leaders, we have to try to see around as many corners as possible. But we are not going to be able to predict the future accurately 100% of the time. And you can't let that paralyse you. You still need to make a call. But if you get down a path and you realise it was the wrong one, it's okay to pivot."

Nickle LaMoreaux
Chief Human Resources Officer, IBM

"No plan B. That may be the most important thing you can do if you really want to make a difference. That's why we didn't have a plan B –because if you have one, that's what you'll end up doing."

Thierry Reboul
Executive Director of Ceremonies, Creative & Special Projects, Paris 2024 Olympic and Paralympic Games

"Often, we don't celebrate academic capability, because we're all equal. But if we want to succeed in that new world, with that complexity, we do need the brightest and the best and we need to be proud of them and make sure they feel absolutely valued."

Mike Fuge
CEO, Contact Energy

"Move slowly and fix things."

Meredith Whittaker
President of Signal

"We need to understand what AI isn't, not just what it is."

Niall Firth
Executive Editor, Newsroom, MIT Technology Review

Five shifts define our messy future. You need to know them, so you can lead through them.

Same shifts, different year

In last year's Skills Horizon we introduced the idea of the decade of disorientation, a turbulent period filled with change, risk, and opportunity.

One year into the decade of disorientation and we've had dozens of chats with leaders to get their thoughts and feelings about our messy future. Reflecting on those conversations, we've noticed something in the air. We call it *ambient uncertainty*: the persistent, low-grade unease that's become the bewildering vibe of everyday life.

It comes from an environment marked by deep fractures and complexity, which can be split into five important Shifts: *The Values Shift, The Technology Shift, The Accountability Shift, The Trust Shift, The Energy Shift*. While you can adapt to them, you can't sidestep them. And as you continue to navigate the decade of disorientation, time and again you'll encounter the five Shifts...

01 THE VALUES SHIFT

Fractured values and fragmenting expectations

The fault lines in your workforce aren't just about preferred communication styles. They're about fundamentally different views of what work is for and how it gets done. The same tensions splitting your teams are splitting your markets, your regulators, and your communities. And every one of your external relationships now requires navigating similar fault lines.

Shifts happen where you least expect them. Almost three-quarters of the youngest generation of workers would rather freelance than become middle managers. Young people across the world are now reporting the highest levels of misery of any age group (Economist 2025b). A quarter of 18- to 34-year-olds never answer the phone (BBC 2024).

There's a growing divergence in attitudes towards feminism, masculinity, and gender equality between young men and young women, and between young men and older generations (Kings College 2025). A recent US poll of Gen Zs showed that, across political and gender lines, there's considerable misalignment in what constitutes a successful life (NBC News 2025b).

Your teams now differ in what careers mean to them, how they relate to each other, and what they expect from their leaders.

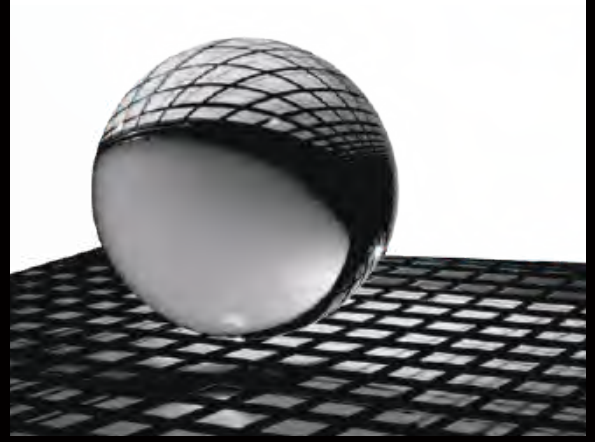
The implications are profound for how we create, let alone maintain, cohesion.

"There's a much bigger generational divide between my generation and my son's generation than between my generation and my parents'. Young people are doing different things and will need to be managed differently."

James Chessell
Editor-in-Chief, The Australian Financial Review

"Technology moves on a much faster arc than culture. You have to be in a constant re-evaluation mode as the technology shifts. Focus on adoption, given your company culture. Has it changed in the way you want it? Is it changing because you're forcing it to change?"

Nickle LaMoreaux
Chief Human Resources Officer, IBM



"Leadership will also involve more of a personal journey to become comfortable and conversant with new technology, and AI won't be the last one. There will be further waves of disruptive technology."

Andrew Shearer
Director-General of the Office of National Intelligence

"Technology is changing in ways that are creating higher degrees of uncertainty, and which are creating a real polarity between winners and losers at a pace that I've not seen before."

James Taylor
Managing Director, SBS

"Anyone in an executive level role needs to be very, very comfortable with AI at this point. Otherwise, you're totally in the dark."

Kelly McJannett
Co-Founder & CEO, Food Ladder

"It's no longer a matter of *if* there is going to be a cyberattack on your company. It's just a matter of when, the magnitude, and most importantly, how you're going to respond to it. Leaders will be judged on their preparedness and their response. Shareholders and customers and governments are not going to be as forgiving in the future."

The Hon. Steven Marshall
President, American Australian Association and Former Premier of South Australia

02 THE TECHNOLOGY SHIFT

Strategic necessities with no clear direction

Technology (AI in particular) is more powerful, more democratised, and more open-ended than ever.

Data, AI, and cyber conversations are happening at every level of your organisation. Are you ready to put AI to work? And are you ready to move on to the productivity and ROI conversation? What's the future shape of your workforce? How do you ensure cyber resilience? The ensuing transformations will run from the front line to the board level. Beyond your office walls (assuming you aren't fully remote), tech is changing society more broadly.

What's unknown is the speed of this transformation. Are we in a bubble? The current moment has all the hallmarks of media hype, and over-investment. OpenAI CEO Sam Altman reportedly said in August 2025: "Are we in a phase where investors as a whole are overexcited about AI? My opinion is yes. Is AI the most important thing to happen in a very long time? My opinion is also yes." Notwithstanding serious implications for investors, businesses, and economies if the bubble bursts, leaders who hold course and understand the transformative nature of AI will benefit.

Technology is also more undefined than ever. While all the building blocks have emerged—vast amounts of data, AI and Gen AI, robotics, digital platforms—the way they fit together isn't quite clear yet. All of us are in R&D now.

03 THE ACCOUNTABILITY SHIFT

Toward dynamic ecosystems of accountability

You need to rethink accountability beyond the boundaries of your organisation.

Your accountability now extends to systems you're embedded in but don't own or control. Sustainability, regulation, global access to capabilities, and the new geopolitics require a shift of perspective from the organisation to the systems level.

Provenance, tracking, and tracing become crucial. Where does your stuff come from? What are your dependencies? What's your level of control? What's your total impact? Actually, not just *your* impact, but that of your suppliers and customers as well?

You live in the provenance economy now. Which means you'll need awareness of the full scope of your supply chain to track the origins of materials, the scope and volume of your carbon emissions, and the impact of your products on the natural, social, and economic worlds.

New requirements, and opportunities, emerge for partnerships with government, suppliers, and competitors across the value chain.

"The prevailing kind of social architecture of the last 20 years is falling away so quickly. We're seeing a collapsing of norms."

Eric Beecher
Chairman, Private Media

"We are entering an era of honesty without the buzzwords. Facts, self-reflection, telling the truth and hearing the truth. We can no longer afford to have conversations that are soft without addressing the issues we need to face and then having the moral fortitude to fix."

Rose Herceg
President, Australia and New Zealand, WPP

"Energy is critical. In many industries, it is the key input. And what I've seen in the energy industry over the last five years is probably more volatility than I've seen in my whole career in energy."

Carolyn Comer
Former President & CEO,
Shell Energy North America

"You need to try to understand how and why trust erodes and what you can do to mitigate that erosion of trust."

The Hon. Andrew Bell
Chief Justice of NSW

"External forces are coming in through compliance and are forcing a change in behaviour and trust between organisations."

Laszlo Peter
CEO, OriginsNext

"Competition around skills is becoming more intense. Take Net Zero: if we don't have enough homegrown skills, we can't just import the skills, because every other country is also doing Net Zero initiatives."

Bernadette Foley
Acting Chief Engineer, Engineers Australia

04 THE TRUST SHIFT

The erosion of trust in institutions, ideas, and geopolitical stabilities

What—and who, for that matter—can you still trust?

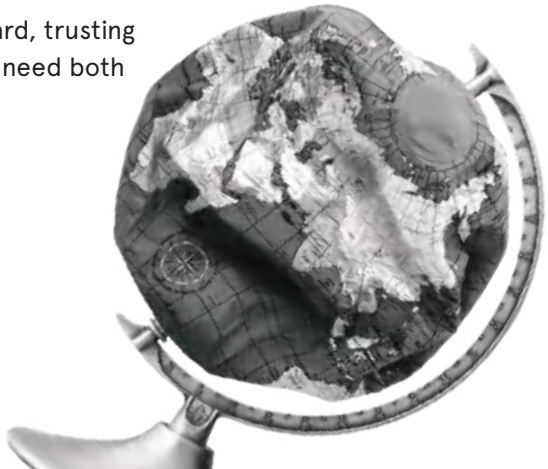
Geopolitical decline is accelerating along trajectories we fail to predict. The global balance of power is shifting faster than the institutional architecture we built to govern our financial, cultural, and power systems can adapt. A new patchwork of coalitions is emerging.

The Trust Shift is dynamically shaping global trade, supply chains, and access to resources. This obscures our ability to forecast long-term trends.

We fear that our leaders lie to us. The belief that government and business leaders, journalists, and media figures say things they know are false or gross exaggerations is at an all-time high (Edelman 2025). And there are more eyes (digital and IRL) than ever on the role of business and their social license to operate.

We worry our roles are threatened by globalisation, a looming recession, automation, and a lack of training. Combined, this could prove extremely destabilising for our organisations.

Earning trust will be hard, trusting even harder. Yet you'll need both more than ever.



05 THE ENERGY SHIFT

The new infrastructures of the digital economy

We're in for a rather inelegant transition.

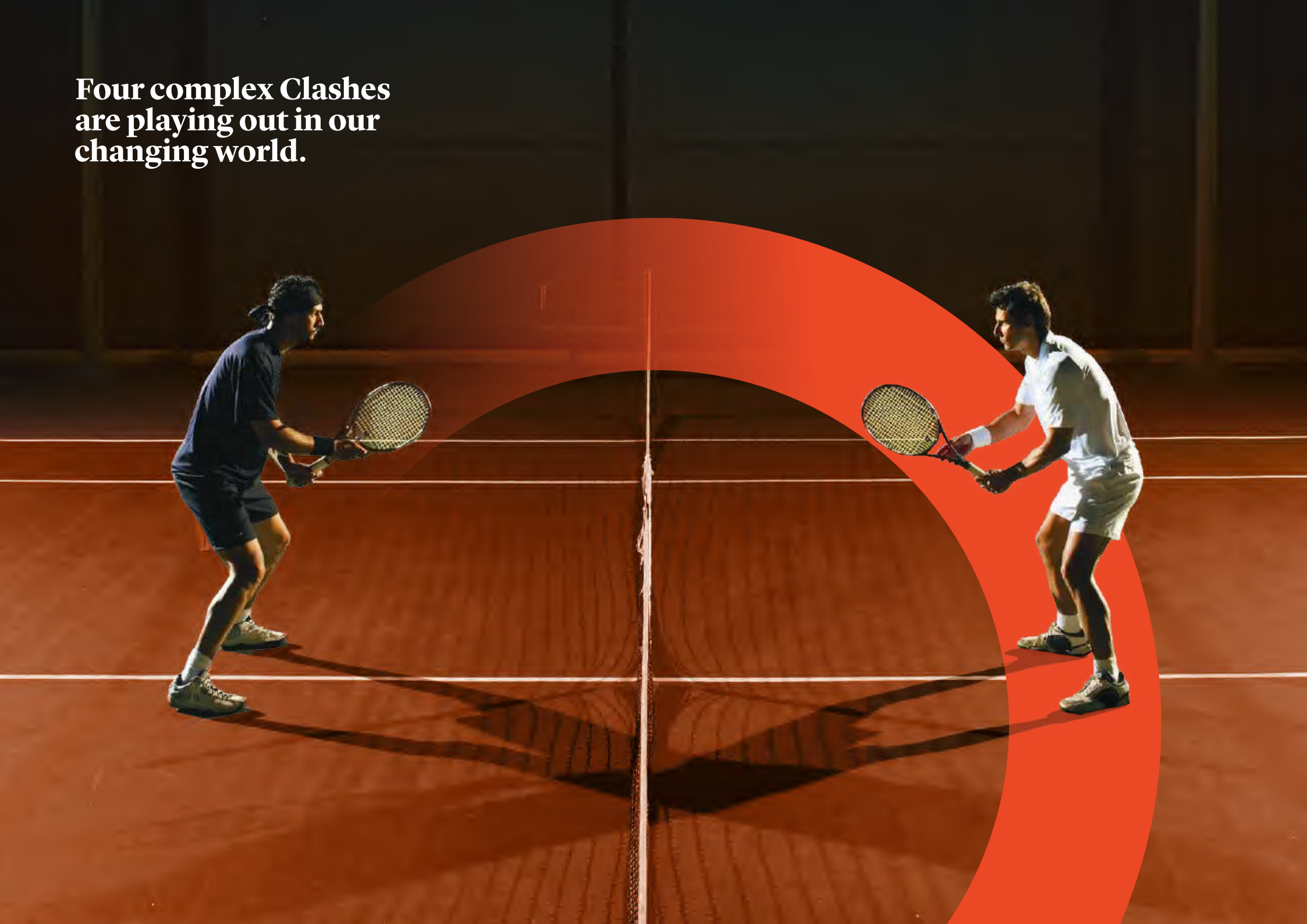
The energy transition will likely be slower, more fragmented, and more complex than we thought. New legislation is dramatically reshaping the US energy landscape, India is reopening 32 defunct mines (Financial Times 2025b) and preparing to launch new greenfield projects, while the amount of wind and solar power under construction in China is now nearly twice as much as the rest of the world combined (Guardian 2024). The changes in materials and natural resources powering the digital and energy transformations drive new geopolitical dependencies.

The promise of AI is (at least for now) also tied to enormous demands for new data centre infrastructure. And data centres have fast become the biggest driver in new energy demand. For nations and organisations, compute power is emerging as one of this decade's most critical resources. The challenge is tremendous: by some accounts, a $7tn surge in capital outlays (McKinsey 2025b).

For you, this Shift means new questions of risk, control, and data and energy sovereignty.

It's a lot, we know. But before we share the skills that'll help you confidently navigate our messy future, we need to cover another priority topic. The five Shifts give rise to a new set of tensions that leaders need to grasp and, ideally, reconcile. We call these Clashes. Read on to get acquainted with them...

Four complex Clashes are playing out in our changing world.



Find your balance

Meet the major tensions you need to negotiate.

"Change is happening more and more rapidly. It is so important for all executives to have a very good, grounded balance."

Carolyn Comer
Former President & CEO,
Shell Energy North America

Shifts lead to Clashes. Things change and move and bump up against each other. Though the term is violent, clashing doesn't have to end in casualties: it can be a case of productive conflict. The main challenge for leaders is understanding these competing forces and figuring out how to balance them in your organisation.

In this section we'll examine the four most urgent Clashes that you'll experience as a leader in 2026. We'll lay out the nuances and importance of both sides and the trade-offs involved in pursuing them.

CLASH 01

Policy vs People

You want organised flexibility

Our organisations face unprecedented diversity. You have people from all walks of life, across multiple generations, each with different values and expectations, sharing a space. Diversity extends to individual views about when and where to work, along with what business is for.

You want to harness diversity... but too much, and coordination becomes impossible.

THE SITUATION

You're a project leader who's had it with the haphazard approach to meetings. So you roll out a new rule. No more Zoom calls in pyjamas. No more dialling in mid-walk at the park. *All ideation sessions must happen in person.*

A couple weeks in and it's working. The team shows up with markers, someone brings snacks, you're basically running the innovation Olympics.

Then comes Thursday's ideation session for a new product line.

UX designer and new dad Craig is MIA. To his credit, he logs in from home (hair sticking up like he just lost a fight with a leaf blower). He apologises—he's on newborn time these days—and the meeting continues.

UX researcher Amy makes a suggestion that gets heads nodding. But the meeting stalls. After what feels like an eternity of frustrating back and forth, the screen lights up, and Craig casually shows the room a rough sketch based on Amy's idea. The team takes a moment to absorb it. Silence. Then applause. "That's genius!" your team exclaim in unison.

And now you're stuck in that awkward manager spot. The policy *has* helped boost collaboration... but Craig just proved that breakthroughs are possible at your kitchen table—all you need is a Sharpie, scrap paper, tech, and some time.

4	First name	Surname	No.	Address 1
5	Liam	Armstrong	475	Second Street
6	Emma	Baker	167	Paul-Revere-Village
7	Noah	Bennett	45	Canal Road
8	Olivia	Black	27	23Rd-Street
9	William	Brown	225	Lee-Highway
10	Ava	Carter	45	Stocker-Street
11	James	Connor	72	Montana Avenue
12	Isabella	Cunningham	207	West-Side-Bridge
13	Oliver	Edison	34	San-Diego-Fairway
14	Sophia	Edwards	63	Regent Street
15	Benjamin	Eliot	102	Ring Road
16	Charlotte	Franklin	18	Maple Trail
17	Elijah	Hanson	81	Field Road
18	Mia	Harper	657	64Rd-Street
19	Lucas	Hilton	36	Raynor Rd
20	Amelia	Hobbs	351	Mountain Road
21	Mason	Jackson	414	Windy Heights Rd
22	Harper	Jenkins	27	Fifth Road
23	Logan	King	234	Arch St.
24	Evelyn	Martin	36	Country Ln
25	Alexander	Michaels	288	Oak Road
26	Abigail	Miller	63	Seventh
27	Ethan	Moore	279	Pine Avenue
28	Emily	Parker	4	Muskiker Ave
29	Jacob	Sawyer	32	Brookside Rd
30	Elizabeth	Shoemaker	279	School St
31	Michael	Smith	81	Elm Avenue
32	Mia	Stark	63	Main St
33	Daniel	Stevenson	81	Washington Ave
34	Ella	Stone	1187	Ninth Road
35	Henry	Thompson	243	Lake Avenue
36	Jackson	Warren	27	High Bridge Rd

The Clash: Policy vs People

Your success as a leader depends on attracting diverse talent, who demand flexibility across work styles, technology preferences, and values. Yet the more you accommodate individuality, the harder it becomes to form a functioning whole. You face a clash between leading with policy and your people's expectations.

You need to find productivity gains and get everyone on the same page. But team members have fundamentally different expectations about where, when, and how to work, communication styles, and purpose. Younger employees expect instant messaging and flexible schedules. Experienced workers prefer email trails and structured processes. Some thrive remotely; others need in-person energy. Too much flexibility makes coordination impossible and burns out middle management—soon, no one wants to be a leader anymore. Apply too much pressure, though, and you lose the team vibe.

Technology amplifies these tensions. Your standardised AI solution ensures security, but some individuals achieve better results with tools that create compliance headaches. You want unified messaging, but authentic social media voices drive more engagement than corporate speak.

Values create the deepest divides. You're pressured to take stances on societal issues, but any position alienates someone.

These tensions aren't new, but they've become more varied and urgent. *The Technology Shift* offers more open, accessible AI tools but threatens compliance. *The Values Shift* creates expectations that diverge more sharply than ever. And you're stuck in the middle: caught between people's expectations and driving organisational outcomes.

ASK YOURSELF

- How do you balance performance and flexibility when accommodating different needs across work styles, tech preferences, and values?
- Where do you require absolute consistency versus beneficial variation, and how do you communicate these trade-offs to your team?
- Do you have the right methods to measure both productivity and coordination costs as flexibility increases?
- Are your leaders equipped to navigate these tensions across different life stages and expectations, or are you burning them out?

"We need leaders that can get the balance right between care and performance."

Leah Weckert
CEO & MD, Coles Group

Policy

Leaders must find productivity in disorienting times. Some leaders have started tightening the screws, mandating a one-size-fits-all approach. AT&T CEO John Stankey put it bluntly: "If a self-directed, virtual, or hybrid work schedule is essential for you to manage your career aspirations and life challenges, you will have a difficult time aligning your priorities with those of the company and the culture we aim to establish" (AFR 2025b).

The pressure is building. About 75% of workers were required in the office some days per week by October 2024, up from 63% in February 2023 (CNBC 2025); 83% of CEOs expect full return-to-office within three years (KPMG 2024).

There's logic here. 83% of workers want their workplace to provide community (Randstad 2025), and 73% feel more connected with colleagues when in the office (Robin 2024). Leaders see presence as essential for cohesion that drives collaboration, innovation, and performance.

Technology creates similar challenges. As more than three-quarters of workers use their own AI tools (Microsoft 2024), some work faster with AI but don't tell their bosses—"hoarding productivity" rather than helping teams improve collectively.

With tightening market conditions, leaders are tightening policy to align organisations and capture productivity gains.

People

Today's talent expects work to match life circumstances and values. Some leaders recognise the need to accommodate personal expectations and the limits of policy to engineer performance. Rio Tinto CEO Jakob Stausholm says: "There are too many companies that try to go to high standards, that doesn't have psychological safety, and it really leads to a very toxic environment... you just don't get people to perform well in a very harsh culture" (AFR 2025c).

The expectations are clear. Work-life balance is now the most important motivator for workers at 83%, overtaking pay at 82% (Randstad 2025).

More dramatically, 44% would quit if they disagreed with leadership values, an 11-point jump from 2024. Young people are particularly uncompromising: 43% have already quit jobs that didn't fit their personal life, compared to 28% of older workers.

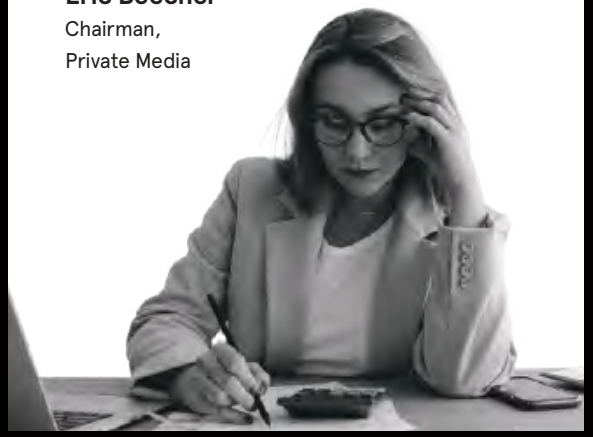
Workers expect leaders to cater for both individuality and community: 55% would quit if they didn't feel they belonged, an 18-point surge from last year (Randstad 2025).

Technology expectations follow similar patterns. People are accustomed to accessing any tools they need online, but 58% of workers aren't satisfied with existing workplace tools, with 63% of Gen Z finding them unreliable and frustrating (Zluri 2024).

Leaders who want to attract broad talent are increasingly asked to accommodate diverse individual needs—or risk talent walking away.

"Leadership has always been about getting the balance right between values and pragmatism and between outcomes and performance. That's been hard enough in normal times. It is getting harder and harder. My big worry is that by following your values you may not keep your job."

Eric Beecher
Chairman,
Private Media

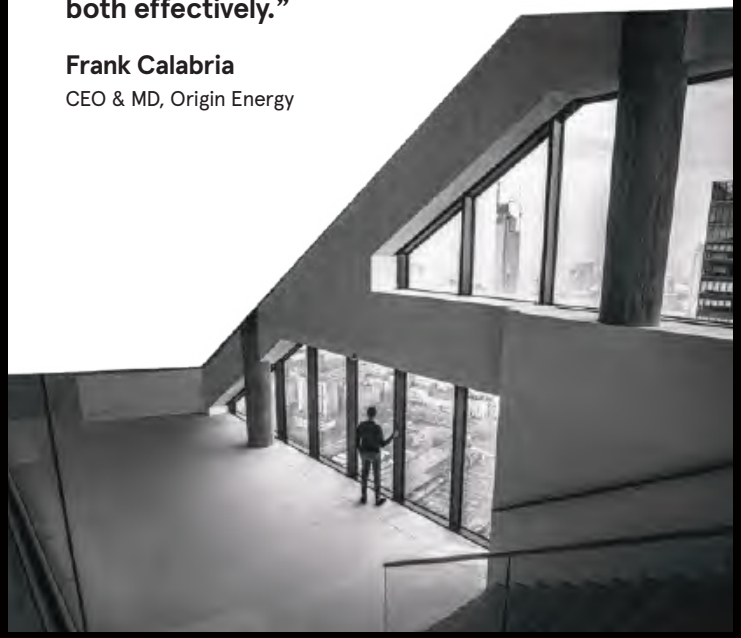


"Today, we often spend much more time discussing how we work, and we easily lose focus on what's relevant and truly matters—that, in the end, we have to deliver a project."

Tino Kuehnel
CEO, byte – Bayerische Agentur für Digitales

"Employees are seeking more autonomy, empowerment, flexibility, and mobility. Leaders are largely supportive of this, but in addition need to drive delivery against strategy and for our stakeholders, so it's about finding ways to facilitate both effectively."

Frank Calabria
CEO & MD, Origin Energy

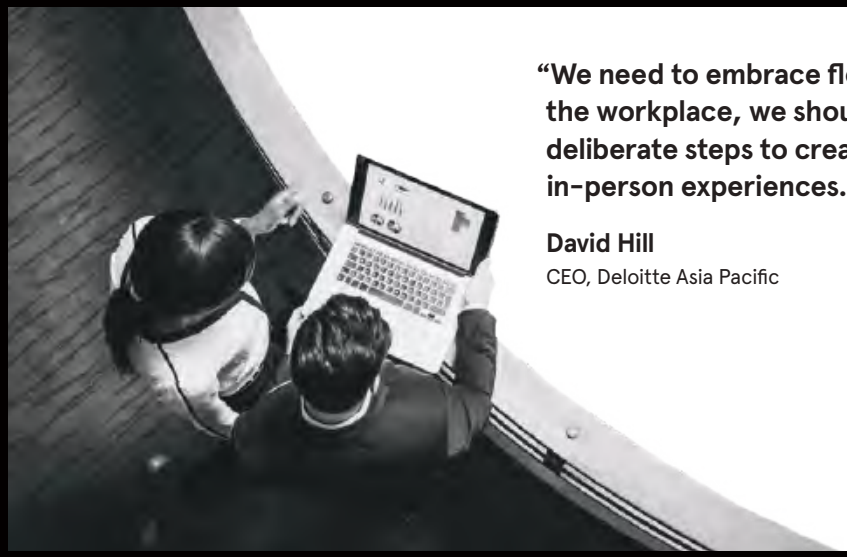


"There is added pressure on leaders who need to be able to deal with a more open culture, who almost need to be psychologists, but also balance that with keeping a team productive, aligned and working towards a goal, even when change is rapidly happening."

Mel Silva
VP & MD, Google Australia & New Zealand

"A big change we're seeing is in the shape of the workforce. Younger workers absolutely 100% want to work differently, they want flexibility, to leverage technology and be recognised as whole people, not just agents of the organisation."

Michelle Bagnall
CEO, Bank First



"We need to embrace flexibility, but in the workplace, we should take very deliberate steps to create memorable in-person experiences."

David Hill
CEO, Deloitte Asia Pacific

"To make sure team members can thrive in our organisation in the future, we need to have a constant flow of creativity coming in to us, we need to be constantly refuelled and inspired. We need to be better at that sort of mental disruption of learning and unlearning."

René Redzepi
Chef & Co-Owner, Noma

"Wellbeing must be balanced with resilience. You may end up with more wellbeing issues in the long run if you don't learn to manage hardship with resilience."

Mike Fuge
CEO, Contact Energy

"You've got to care for people and invest in people, in their development, in making people feel that they belong in an organisation, that they are included. Having an inclusive culture in the workplace is different to having policies."

Justin D'Agostino
Global CEO, Herbert Smith Freehills Kramer

"When technology becomes the medium for discourse it can lead to a less creative, less enhancing dialogue. People still need to be in the same room, iteratively taking risks with conversation to enable true creativity."

Robert Thomson
Chief Executive, News Corp

CLASH 02

Efficiency vs Expertise

You want to move fast, and not break things

AI is fast becoming a competitive necessity, its availability expected by employees and stakeholders. The technology promises to unlock new efficiencies and a step change in productivity. But there isn't a straight line between its rollout and those gains. It's much more complicated than the AI hype has you believe.

THE SITUATION

Marc is a mid-level marketing manager who has become his team's "content wizard". Marc's presentations are flawless, his copy compelling, and his output seemingly endless. Everyone marvels at his productivity... unaware that Marc hasn't written an original sentence in months. Instead, he feeds prompts to a Gen AI platform, takes the output that "feels right", makes minor tweaks, and *voilà*.

You've met them. Colleagues who present flawlessly articulated ideas they can't defend. Managers who present complex ideas with confidence until challenged. People who are productive but can't explain what they're doing (or why). We call them 'vibers' (AFR 2025a), and they perform expertise without genuinely developing it. Because AI can be highly seductive (PNAS 2025), it's able to speak our language and lets us prioritise content that "just feels right".

The Clash: Efficiency vs Expertise

"In the context of AI, I think it's deeply important to feel a sense of obligation that our people have entrusted their careers and futures to us and that I and all of my leaders have a reciprocal obligation to them."

David Hill
CEO, Deloitte Asia Pacific

AI promises to do more with less. The "more" sounds appealing. But what happens when "less" means *less* attention, *less* thinking, and *less* expertise? Yes, your teams can produce more output in less time. But research suggests AI leads to cognitive offloading, and people may stop developing the skills that create genuine value. You face the clash of having to find efficiency gains with AI, without losing the very expertise that will set you apart in the market.

The more individuals delegate thinking to AI, the more they become dependent on outputs they can't evaluate. Vibers might look productive, but they're sacrificing expertise. And when junior roles disappear because AI-enabled seniors can handle the workload, organisations diminish their talent pipeline.

Yet in a market where everyone has the same AI tools, human expertise becomes the differentiator. Domain experts can craft better prompts, recognise AI's limitations, and integrate outputs meaningfully. For those with deep expertise, AI becomes an amplifier.

You face a fundamental tension—for yourself and for your team. AI promises productivity gains; it can amplify expertise. But it also threatens to degrade it, replace it, or prevent it from developing.

Cognitive offloading isn't new. GPS replaced map reading, calculators took over basic math. We don't mourn these losses because the skills weren't central to most people's work. But with AI things are different. It promises to handle core business functions, the very heart of knowledge work.

You can't afford to ignore AI. Can you afford offloading your work to it?

ASK YOURSELF

- Are your teams equipped to make good choices about the use of AI, beyond individual prompting?
- Have you done a work analysis of your core work areas to tailor AI deployment and use?
- What is your approach to developing expertise in junior workers when AI is here to pick up entry-level tasks?
- Are you rethinking incentive structures and KPIs to be fit for a world of AI-enabled work?

Efficiency

AI productivity promises are everywhere. McKinsey (2025) puts the "long-term productivity growth potential" from AI at $4.4tn globally. The picture at the individual business level is still hazy, but a range of studies show that, if well managed, AI can lift productivity significantly.

Students using AI chatbots took 40% less time to complete tasks, with higher quality, than peers without AI (MIT 2023); coders at Australian bank Westpac showed 46% productivity gains, again with no loss in quality (ITNews 2023); call centre workers at a large US IT company saw a 15% average productivity gain (Brynjolfsson et al. 2025); and in a controlled experiment, consultants at BCG completed 12% more tasks and 25% faster than those without AI (HBS 2023). Studies by Microsoft (2024b) and Atlassian (2024) both report time savings of around one hour per day for at least half of respondents.

Results like these have executives worldwide demanding AI use from their workers; clients are asking professional services firms for a productivity dividend. AI use for productivity is increasingly assumed, not a choice.

Expertise

When used with skill and experience, AI can amplify expertise. Yet, concerns about AI's impact on expertise are also growing—not just at the organisational level, but more worryingly, at the individual level.

Students using a coding LLM for a programming task in an unknown language were much faster than those without, but failed their exam and lacked understanding (ACM 2024). Students using AI chatbots in a series of essay tasks showed much lower brain activity than those without AI; most concerningly, the lower activation persisted in a subsequent task where no AI was available (MIT 2025). Another study revealed a strong link between intensive AI use and a lack in critical thinking abilities, mediated by increased cognitive offloading (Gerlich 2025). AI use has also been shown to lower intrinsic motivation by an average of 11% and increase boredom by 20% (HBR 2025).

These results have educators, researchers, and managers worried that AI might hamper skill development and deplete an organisation's expertise base, especially when left unmanaged.

"AI will transform how we work, in the same way computers and smartphones did before. This will be an important step in fighting the productivity crisis we see in many countries."

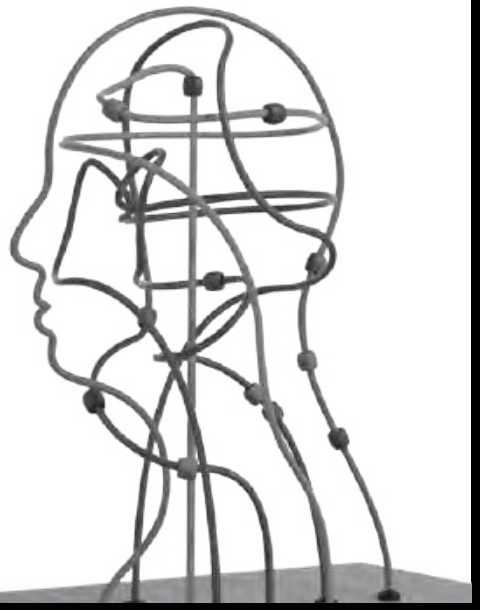
Wilson White
Vice President, Government Affairs & Public Policy, Google

"What are the right problems to solve? What are tasks that put constraints on your work? If you could solve one of those problems with AI, bring down the time it takes from days to seconds, how would this collapse outcomes in y our space?"

Morgan Brown
VP Product & Growth - AI Products, Dropbox

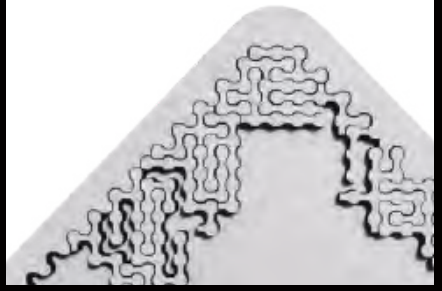
"I'm re-evaluating many parts of how I operate. If I was reinventing my role, or hiring my replacement and AI exists, how would I design it from scratch?"

Dom Price
Former Work Futurist, Atlassian



"I don't think we've even scraped the surface of the potential of AI as we move from the personal use to the company use and to the sectoral use."

The Hon. Steven Marshall
President, American Australian Association and Former Premier of South Australia



"One of the most powerful skills that leaders need to have is the skill of questioning. What is prompt engineering? It's essentially a questioning skill."

The Hon. Victor Dominello
CEO, Future Government Institute

"We're going to have to drive productivity very hard."

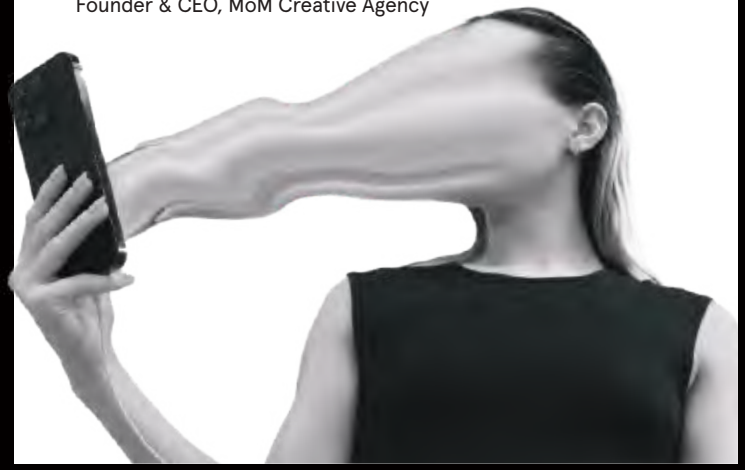
Leah Weckert
CEO & MD, Coles Group

"Your job is going to change. Don't let anybody believe that it's not going to change."

Brad Shaw
CEO, livepro

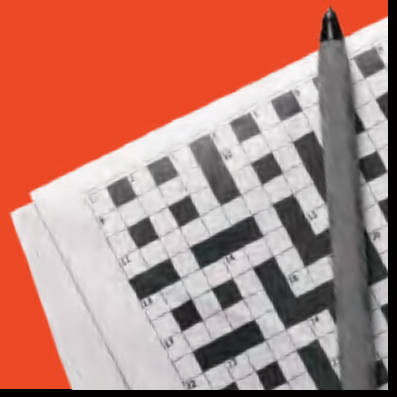
"We are going through an AI transformation, and what we see is that senior talent are getting amplified, they are getting better and working faster. But junior talent is getting worse, and they are getting too comfortable using AI. As AI provides the answers, they are not developing curiosity and skill."

Rafael Sang
Founder & CEO, MoM Creative Agency



"I worry a bit with this path to automation. I think there is joy in doing work, and there's a certain risk in leisure. People who do office work, we need to run on a treadmill at night just to move our bodies, because work is no longer physical. Now I'm worried that we're going to automate our brain work. Are we going to have to do crossword puzzles just to think, or our brains will atrophy?"

Christian Beaudoin
Global Head of Marketing, JLL Work Dynamics



"How do you find or develop individuals that are capable of not just having creative expertise, but a level of comfort of working with technology that can support their creative skill set?"

The Hon. Andrew Bell
Chief Justice of NSW

"How much should be automated and how much be imagined by humans? We must learn where the line is when it comes to the creative process."

Rose Herceg
President, Australia
and New Zealand, WPP

"How do you find or develop individuals that are capable of not just having creative expertise, but a level of comfort of working with technology that can support their creative skill set?"

Paul Grosmann
CEO, R.M.Williams

CLASH 03

Capability vs Control

You want all the power, with none of the risk

Modern business demands capabilities your organisation cannot build and possess alone. Complex products, digitised services, and AI-driven processes have to be sourced broadly, from international suppliers, cloud platforms, and talent networks. Yet the world has become less predictable. Supply chain disruptions ripple globally. And new legal requirements loom large.

THE SITUATION

Clara is the chief legal officer for a large Australian research university. Staff constantly bombard her team with policy questions, so Clara built a prototype AI chatbot that could instantly answer queries by connecting the university's public policy database to ChatGPT.

Clara thought she'd found the perfect solution... until staff began submitting deeply personal questions ("Can I take mental health leave if my supervisor is bullying me?"), potentially disclosing sensitive information to offshore servers. Clara's innovation ground to a frustrating halt. Data protection requirements and sovereignty concerns meant she couldn't use the chatbot. The project stalled for months until a capable AI solution became available in an onshore data centre.

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The Clash: Capability vs Control

> **"Partnerships with external capabilities are becoming increasingly crucial. Organisations need to be able to leverage non-core capabilities to own value creation end to end. You need to build deep relationships with external partners, for flexibility, speed to market, redundancy, and to be less capital intensive."**
>
> **Matthew Saxon**
> Chief People Officer, Zoom

Your organisation's competitiveness depends on assets and services you cannot possibly all develop in-house. You're faced with the clash of needing to expand capabilities externally, at a time when you also need to exert greater control.

The AI models transforming your industry exist only on hyperscaler platforms. The specialised talent you need works freelance, not full-time. Your increasingly complex products require components from global suppliers with expertise you'll never match. Even your basic business software now comes with cloud dependencies and regular updates beyond your control.

But the world has become a riskier place to operate. Supply chain disruptions can halt production. Data sovereignty regulations mean you need to know exactly where information is processed and stored. Your digitised products, from smart equipment to electric vehicles, collect vast amounts of data and remain vulnerable to remote disabling or software obsolescence.

The fundamental tension is inescapable: the more you tap external capabilities, the less control you retain. Yet increasing complexity requires greater capability, while regulators and stakeholders demand more control and visibility.

Clara's university faced this Clash when a simple chatbot became a data sovereignty issue. Manufacturers face it when critical components come from a single supplier in a geopolitically unstable region. Retail companies encounter it when cloud infrastructure decisions determine where customer data flows.

But reducing risks and tightening control comes at a cost. Building capabilities in-house takes years and might be too expensive. Keeping everything onshore limits your talent pool and inflates costs.

The solution lies in finding balance, which demands your strategic attention.

How will you manage the Clash between capability and control?

ASK YOURSELF

- Have you mapped which external capabilities are truly critical versus nice-to-have?
- Do you know what level of external visibility you need to meet regulatory requirements?
- Are you designing products and services with controllability in mind or retrofitting control after decisions are made?
- How are you balancing the cost of control against the risk of losing it, and who makes these trade-off decisions in your organisation?

Capability

Competitiveness in a complex world requires accessing specialised capabilities, often globally, that would be prohibitively expensive to develop in-house.

Global sourcing is alive and kicking, despite trade tensions and geopolitical conflicts. For example, two-thirds of companies worldwide plan to maintain or expand business with China in 2025 (QIMA 2025). In fashion, offshoring increased by 16% as the primary sourcing strategy, while nearshoring dropped from 30% to 10% (Interline 2025).

Specialist talent increasingly operates outside traditional employment structures. Nearly half of businesses turn to freelancers to address critical skill gaps, with 48% of CEOs planning to increase freelance hiring (Upwork 2025).

In IT, cloud-based software has become the default to access and scale capability. The global SaaS market will grow 118% to $783bn by 2030, while 85% of new applications are now SaaS-based (Hostinger 2025).

Meanwhile, physical products gain new smart capabilities through digitisation. The market for embedded systems is growing 60% to $162bn by 2030 (Fortune BI 2025). In property, building automation systems will nearly double to $205bn (Yahoo Finance 2025).

In each case, new capabilities that are increasingly impossible to service in-house are accessed externally instead.

Control

Global sourcing, and new digital dependencies from cloud services and smart devices, expose organisations to risks they struggle to control, monitor, or mitigate.

Increasingly, critical materials or parts are controlled by a single country or supplier, creating chokepoints beyond any organisation's influence. For example, China dominates 80% of battery production and processing (OECD 2023). TSMC manufactures 100% of the latest generation chips, using lithography machines exclusively from ASML in the Netherlands (Allianz 2025).

AI capabilities are heavily concentrated. Only 32 countries possess large AI data centres, with American and Chinese companies operating more than 90% of the facilities other organisations rely on (NYT 2025).

Digitisation introduces dependencies that can strand assets overnight. US farmers lose $4.2bn annually from software-restricted equipment repairs (NBC News 2025a). Electric vehicle fleets have been stranded when manufacturers stopped software updates. The same happens in buildings, where the asset often outlives its automation software. Even militaries face control and sovereignty risks: the F-35 fighter jet depends on remote software updates for combat readiness (Aviationist 2025).

What do you actually control when your assets can be remotely disabled or face obsolescence overnight?

"We need to be more globally minded around where solutions are found, how we evolve, how we deliver for today and invest in tomorrow."

Nicky Sparshott
Former Global Chief of Transformation, Unilever

"Understanding geopolitics and political risk becomes more important even if you're in a small business, as shifts can come really fast."

Kristel Van der Elst
Director General, Policy Horizons Canada

"Suddenly organisations realise that this kind of problem cannot be solved by one organisation. It's just very complex for everyone to piece together the complex supply chain."

Laszlo Peter
CEO, OriginsNext

"For a long time, we've built efficient supply chains, for competitive, comparative advantage. Now, we're moving away from globalisation almost to balkanisation, and to resilient supply chains rather than necessarily efficiency first."

The Hon. Steven Marshall
President, American Australian Association and Former Premier of South Australia

"Leaders need to look at systems-of-systems, such as geopolitical systems. The complexity and the interconnectedness of everything that is occurring needs to be front and centre. The bigger picture is continually evolving and changing."

Bernadette Foley
Acting Chief Engineer, Engineers Australia

"The dynamics of what is a good site, a good location, changes. It is no longer enough to be in a population centre with good access to labour. A good site now must have access to power, to energy, and access to sustainable resources."

Christian Beaudoin
Global Head of Marketing, JLL Work Dynamics

"With AI, innovation needs to be different. When a core technology develops so rapidly, and outside of the organisation, R&D has to be more agile. This includes integrating and harnessing ideas from the external ecosystem, including start-ups."

Michael Spranger
President, Sony AI; COO, Sony Research

"We need to adapt internal practices to be tolerant of a certain amount of risk-taking behaviour and support the creation process at scale."

Tony Surtees AM
Chairman, Food Ladder

"Executives will need to be better at speaking the language of the public sector. They will need to invest in ability and invest time to constantly talk to and interact with policymakers and regulators."

Dragoș Tudorache
Member of the European Parliament and Vice-President of the Renew Europe Group

"Uncertainty is the new business baseline, leaders need to go beyond simply accepting this point, to fully embracing it. If you are a leader that craves certainty, how can you wake up in the morning and actually find you've got the headspace and capacity to deal with all the uncertainty that's out there?"

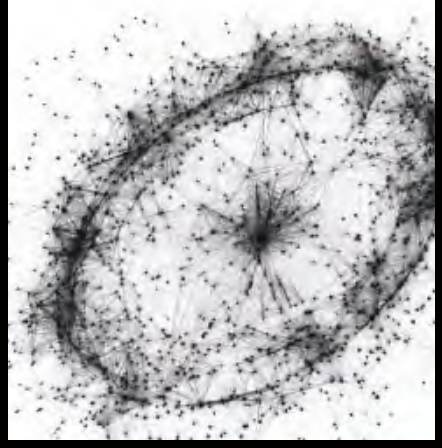
Justin D'Agostino
Global CEO, Herbert Smith Freehills Kramer

"I don't think you can be a leader of an organisation now, particularly in large organisations, without engaging with policy and being an active participant in the government process."

Bran Black
Chief Executive,
Business Council of Australia

"If you want to keep data private don't collect it."

Meredith Whittaker
President of Signal



CLASH 04

Abundance vs Attention

You want to focus on everything

You need to stay informed across a sprawling number of big issues, like tracking how AI is (re)shaping your industry, monitoring shifting global dynamics, and keeping on top of multigenerational workforce trends. The cost of missing a critical development is too high to ignore. Yet in today's information environment, it's a seemingly impossible balancing act.

THE SITUATION

Your sacred ritual: three newspapers before coffee, five newsletters with breakfast, podcasts syncing as you grab your keys. You've got alerts for AI, trade, regulatory changes. Knowledge is power, right?

Then Monday explodes. New AI regulations over the weekend. Tariff changes hitting your suppliers. A competitor just launched something that shouldn't exist yet.

You take a deep breath and dive in. Every article spawns three more tabs. But your feeds keep pulling you sideways: LinkedIn serves up hot takes, your news app pushes "related" stories that aren't. Meg from finance interrupts: "How do the trade changes affect Q2?" You're mid-sentence when marketing pings: "Does that AI tool violate privacy law?" You've started three responses, finished none. *Where* do you focus? *How* can you focus?

"Board moved the meeting up. They want the brief now." You frantically prompt your AI assistant. It drowns you in advice made obsolete by the very changes you're trying to understand.

You stare at your screen: an ocean of information, a desert of insight.

The Clash: Abundance vs Attention

"There is so much noise. You must be able to differentiate what's worth reading and following. And the volume of it is such that it's difficult to keep on top when you've got a lot of other responsibilities. You need to make time to educate yourself, to reflect and then to articulate your thoughts."

The Hon. Andrew Bell
Chief Justice of NSW

The task couldn't be clearer: you need to find the signal in the noise. Yet you're faced with a clash between an abundance of channels, sources, and content, plus the need to pay attention to more and more issues.

Your attention is fractured before you even begin. Algorithms meant to personalise and curate trap you in filter bubbles that narrow your perspective. Optimised for engagement, they serve up endless suggestions to keep you scrolling. You get both too little diversity and too much distraction. The very systems meant to organise information actively fragment your focus.

Meanwhile, content explodes exponentially across multiplying channels. News cycles compress from daily to hourly to instantaneously–leaving no time for reflection or synthesis. You're managing LinkedIn, Threads, TikTok, Substacks, podcasts–each with distinct benefits and noise patterns. The signal you desperately need gets lost in a sea that grows deeper and murkier by the minute.

Then there's synthetic pollution. AI-generated content floods every channel, leaving you exhausted and exasperated after constantly questioning: *Is this true? Can I use this?* Deepfakes mix with genuine news, chatbot-written articles masquerade as journalism, and distinguishing authentic information becomes a full-time job.

Your AI assistants promise to help but can make matters worse. While they excel at many tasks, news is not their forte. In fact, research shows that AI summaries are least effective with news, missing crucial insights and context (BBC 2025). That leaves you needing to not just fact-check sources but also verify your digital advisors.

You have to balance these tensions. You can't afford to miss critical developments, yet the information environment actively works against your ability to focus. Noise is abundant, but the tools that should empower better decisions are shattering the very attention you need to make them.

ASK YOURSELF

- What's the minimum viable information you need to make good decisions in your role?
- How much time do you spend gathering information versus processing and acting on what you learn?
- Are you responding to information strategically or just reacting to it in the moment?
- Can you tell the difference between feeling informed and genuinely creating clarity for others?

Abundance

The amount of online content has exploded and the number of apps and channels has mushroomed—but so has the noise.

The global volume of data online stands at 180 zettabytes (Statista 2025)—the equivalent of 45tn DVDs worth of data—90% of which was created in the past two years.

In addition to content, the number of channels for news and information has grown. There are Substacks, podcasts, blogs, newsletters. Social media has fragmented—instead of just Twitter, we now have X, Bluesky, Threads, WeChat and others.

More than ever, users get their news on social media. In the US, it's now the main source, with 54% of people saying they use it, ahead of TV (50%) and actual news sites and apps (48%) (BBC 2025b). And 39% of young adults regularly get their news on TikTok (Pew 2024), where fewer than 1% of accounts are run by traditional media.

Then there's AI, which fuels content growth. Your social media feed is being inundated with slop: AI-generated content low in news nutrients. 54% of longer posts on LinkedIn are now AI-generated (Wired 2025). As a result, the average reach of posts has dropped by 50% in just six months (Inc 2025), making the signal-to-noise ratio even worse.

Attention

The tools we use are fracturing, distracting, and misdirecting our attention at a time where we need more of it, not less.

Our work tools, intended to keep us informed, have fractured our attention. The average worker receives 117 emails and 153 short messages daily. The average time between interruptions is down to two minutes. And 52% of leaders say their workday is chaotic (Microsoft 2025).

Online we fare no better. News feed algorithms on social media serve us what we want, but in the process create echo chambers (PNAS 2021), configuring our attention by narrowing our field of vision.

AI Overviews promise quick news bites, but they've cut traffic to websites by 30% to 70% (Ahrefs 2025, Seer 2024), diverting our attention away from the actual source of information.

But AI summaries are not reliable for news content. In an experiment, the BBC found that in more than half of cases AI news summaries had significant issues; in 19% the AI introduced factual errors (BBC 2025a).

AI-based search tools promise to quickly synthesise results with AI, but have issues of their own, with frequent hallucinations of numbers and facts. This wastes our time and further fractures our attention.

"The signal-to-noise ratio is a really big deal now. Working through the mire of opinions and platitudes into what do we really need to focus on? You've got to have a very clear understanding of how and where your business creates value."

Ian Narev
CEO & MD, SEEK

"It's difficult for a business trying to navigate crazy news every day, because you're constantly bombarded with information and your decision-making ability is sort of worn down."

Eamon Waterford
CEO, Committee for Sydney

"It will be difficult for leaders to keep on top of the actual conversation that their constituency is having. There are different people on different platforms with different ideas. I think you have to change your expectations about what a well-managed business is going to be like, and accept the messiness"

James Chessell
Editor-in-Chief, The Australian Financial Review

"The business environment is more complex today than it's ever been. There's information coming at l eaders every minute, every day and they're trying to work out what's hype, what do I prioritise and what do I need to take seriously?"

Paul Zahra
Non-Executive Director & Former
CEO Australian Retailers Association

"Leaders need new data literacy, or analytical literacy. They are being presented by their employees with information from a range of sources; you need to know what is reasonable, what is true or real."

Christian Beaudoin
Global Head of Marketing,
JLL Work Dynamics

"I try to be intentional about what's the signal in the noise. We're just bombarded with noise, no matter where you get your news or your information from. And when you overlay with the noise the emotion that comes with that, it's a lot to sift through."

Kiersten Robinson
Chief People Officer, Commonwealth Bank

"Misinformation and disinformation impacts institutions in huge ways. Business leaders need to retain their acumen around what is true and how to test information and how to source things with an evidence lens so that they're in a position to respond and to push back."

Lisa Annese
CEO, Chief Executive Women

"With so many sources of information now, it can be increasingly difficult to know where the truth actually lies—you need data and intuition as you apply critical thinking."

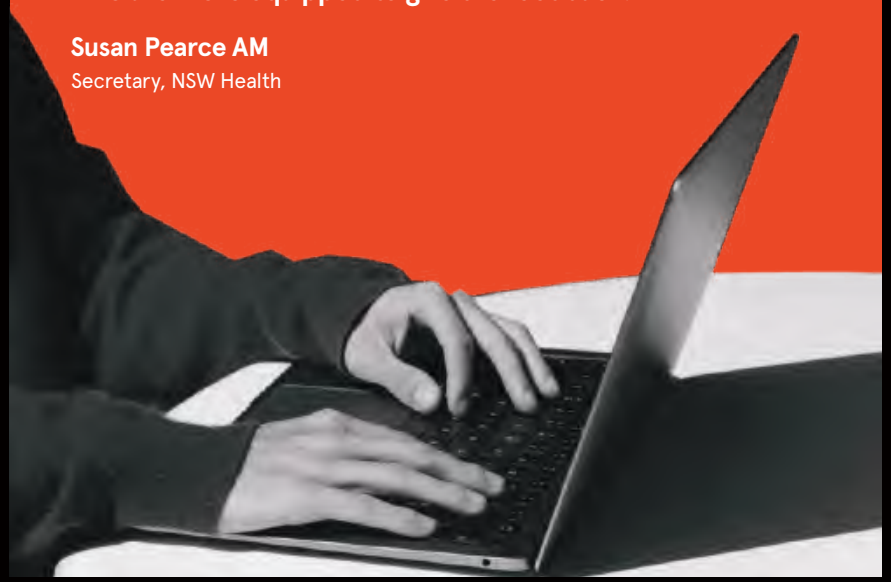
Nicky Sparshott
Former Global Chief of Transformation, Unilever

"I want to know what's real and what's not."

Rose Herceg
President, Australia and New Zealand, WPP

"We've got to equip people with the skills to manage in the era of social media, with very different and more rapid interaction with patients and carers and consumers who are more equipped to give the feedback."

Susan Pearce AM
Secretary, NSW Health



"The incredible uncertainty, misinformation, and disinformation is deeply disturbing for many young people."

David Hill
CEO, Deloitte Asia Pacific

"The capacity for an organisation or a team of people to be discerning about the information that they're dealing with, not just relying on the leader to ask hard questions, is going to be key to success going forward."

Rodd Staples
Chief of Transport, Qiddiya

"We need to upskill employees to understand the difference between traditional sources of information and generative AI. We cannot just wait until the technology has improved, we need to continue working with it."

Heather Domin
Vice President and Head of Office of Responsible AI and Governance, HCLTech

“Move slowly and fix things.”

Meredith Whittaker
President of Signal

Leading the next decade

Your guide to navigating what's ahead

How do you lead in a world that's becoming increasingly disoriented and disorienting? In a world fuelled by Shifts that fracture established orders and challenge proven approaches? In a world where you need to both grasp and balance the Clashes that shape business and society?

THE RESPONSE IS LEARNING AND UPSKILLING

You'll need to reorient yourself and be responsive to the coming changes to understand emerging risks and make use of new opportunities. You'll need to learn new skills and unlearn old ones. You'll need to craft initiatives to upskill your leadership teams.

THE SKILLS HORIZON PROVIDES ORIENTATION

It tells you what you need to know now, what to learn next, and what to look out for. The Skills Horizon is your guide to navigating what lies ahead, through learning and upskilling. It provides you with a strategic lens for prioritising your organisation's leader development.

WHAT WE TAKE FOR GRANTED

New skills always build on existing capabilities. They're most effective when they're met by deep expertise. The Skills Horizon distils responses to emerging shifts in the environment into key skills to learn and master.

Horizon skills complement and amplify your expertise and capabilities as a leader. Postgraduate degrees offer pathways for professional specialisation and career change. Skills build on that formative education and the deep expertise you build on the job.

You won't find foundational capabilities on the Skills Horizon. We expect you already know that disruptive times call for critical thinking, creative problem-solving, and emotional intelligence. You don't need the Skills Horizon to tell you that.

For everything else, we invite you to keep reading...

“The world changes slowly and then very quickly.”

Professor Mark Scott AO
Vice-Chancellor and President
The University of Sydney

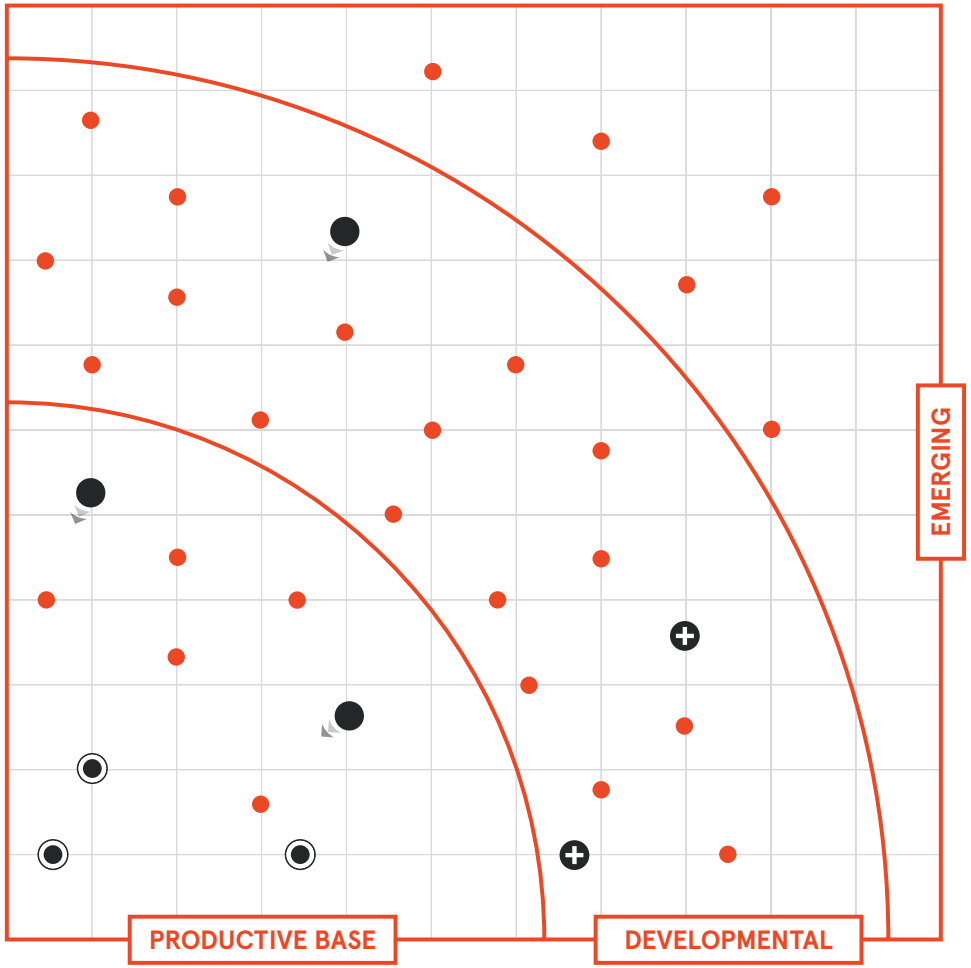
A closer look at the Skills Horizon

What it is and how to read it

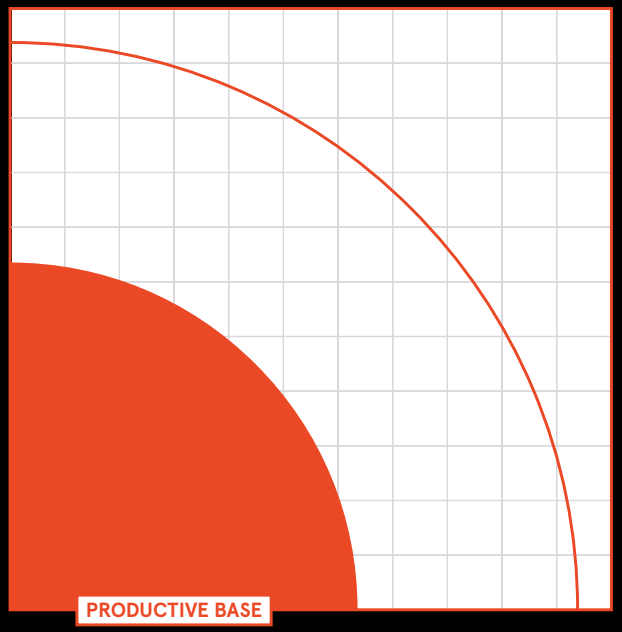
The Skills Horizon is a visual representation of the things you need to know now, what you should be learning next, and what you should consider exploring.

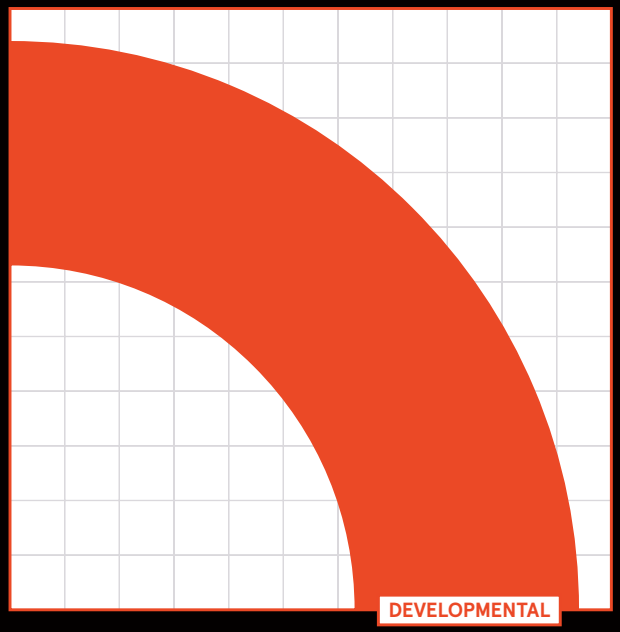
It takes in-depth qualitative and quantitative analyses and provides actionable recommendations and insight into the relevancy, maturity, and criticality of skills required to thrive in a decade of disorientation. Understanding our methodology will help you get the most out of the Skills Horizon when you use it to evaluate your own skills, your team's skills, resourcing, skills development, and career management.

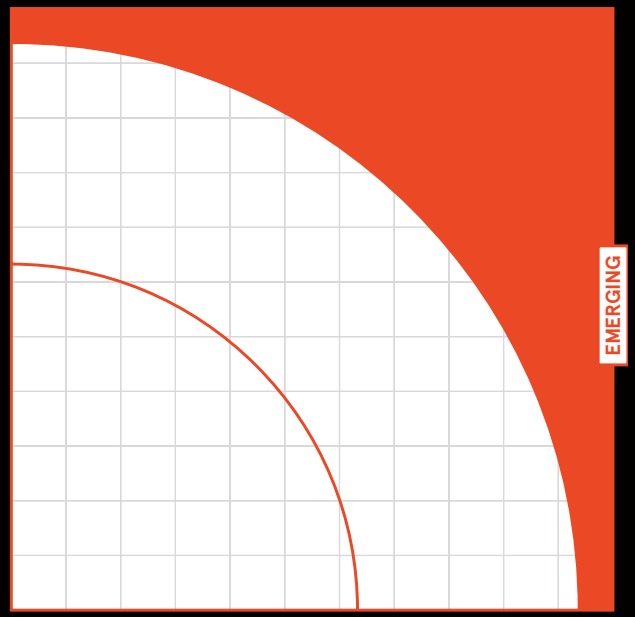
The Skills Horizon cautions against short-lived needs and instead helps with strategy and strategic planning, capability mapping, and strengths assessments.



Today, soon, years from now. We position skills on three horizons, based on their urgency:







PRODUCTIVE SKILLS

These are things you need to know now. The critical skills that should be acquired or honed immediately; baseline capabilities you need for successful ongoing management and leadership.

All current and emerging leaders require this essential core to operate effectively in our changing world.

DEVELOPMENTAL RANGE

This is what you need to learn next. Developing these skills will prepare you for near-term opportunities and risks.

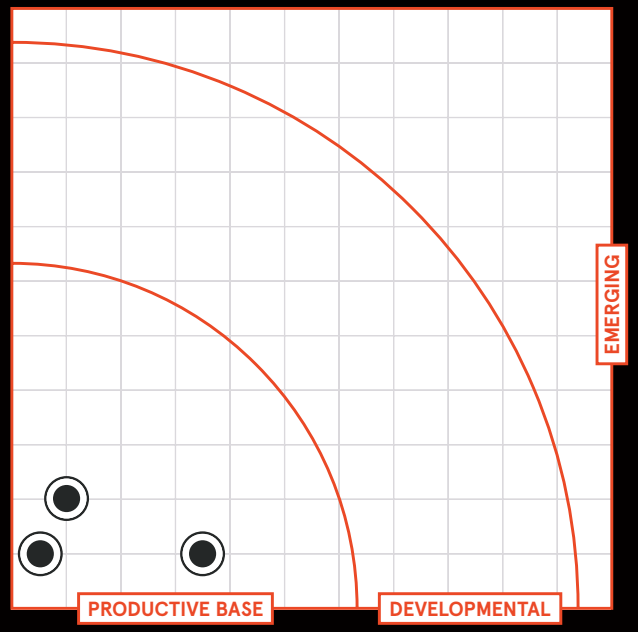
Skills that are in the developmental range have come into focus. Forward-thinking current and emerging leaders are already adding them to their core.

EMERGING SKILLS

This is where you need to explore. You should consider these for the longer term because they could be gamechangers. New business models could emerge, entire industries could be reshaped, and novel risks might surface.

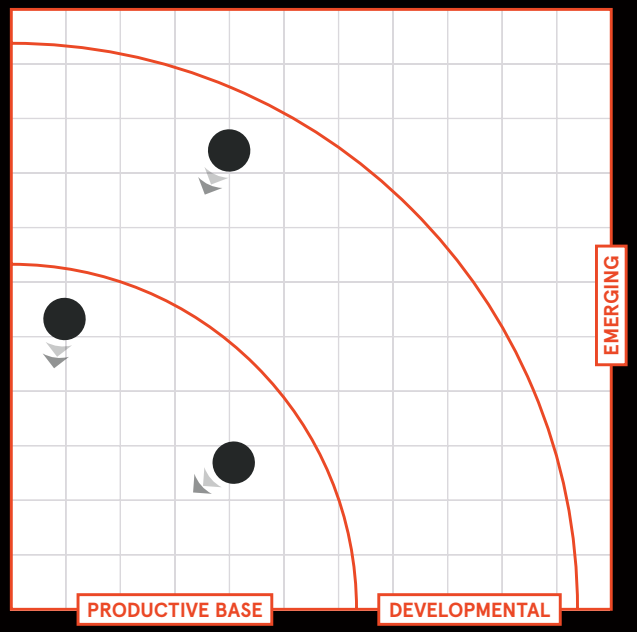
These skills might become essential in the next decade. Strategic, future-focused leaders and emerging leaders will experiment with these early to future-proof their organisations.

Skills operate in different ways. We've identified three categories of interesting moves that deserve special attention:



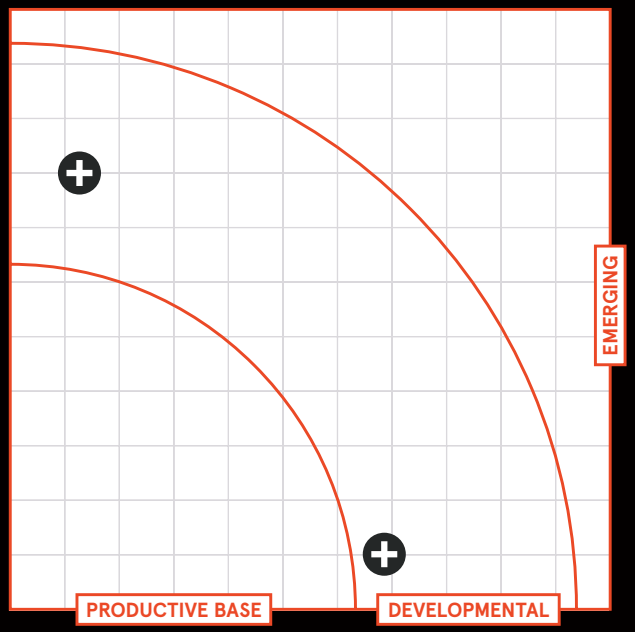
AMPLIFIERS

These skills have the potential to dramatically speed up or enhance other capabilities. They're force multipliers that can help you make your organisation more productive, take advantage of other skills, or gain an edge on your competition.



MOVERS

These are skills that may have been on the radar for a longer time but have suddenly become critical to success or moved from the fringes into the developmental range.

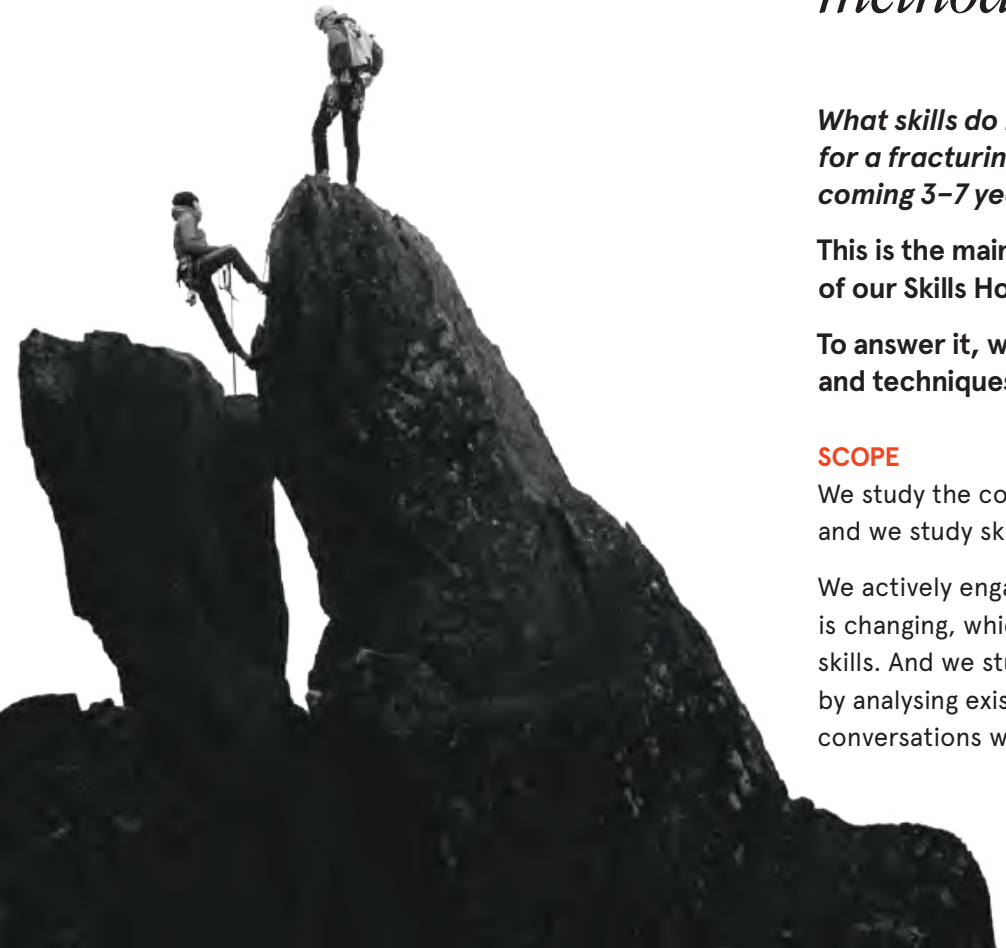


UNEXPECTED EMERGERS

These skills have quickly risen to prominence due to changing circumstances. These are the new wildcards that can catch you and your organisation off guard if you're not paying attention, but which could lead to big opportunities if used effectively.

How we built it

Breaking down our methodology



What skills do leaders need to prepare for a fracturing world—now, and for the coming 3–7 years?

This is the main question at the heart of our Skills Horizon research.

To answer it, we draw on a variety of sources and techniques, across three dimensions:

SCOPE

We study the context in which skills are needed, and we study skills directly.

We actively engage with how the world around us is changing, which drives the requirements for new skills. And we study the need for new skills directly by analysing existing skills reports, and through our conversations with leaders around the world.

TIMELINES

We look back and we look forward. We study existing materials available in the public domain: skills reports and various media that focus on the future of business, society, and leadership. And we practice strategic foresight, using signals we observe in the environment and eliciting the views and intuitions of leaders in their fields to understand emerging skills requirements.

SOURCES

We incorporate public material, and we collect and create our own. We tap into the public conversation around change and skills, as it unfolds in both the media and research. And we engage in private conversations with a diverse group of senior leaders, as well as hold our own private conversations, using foresight techniques to make sense of the future of business.

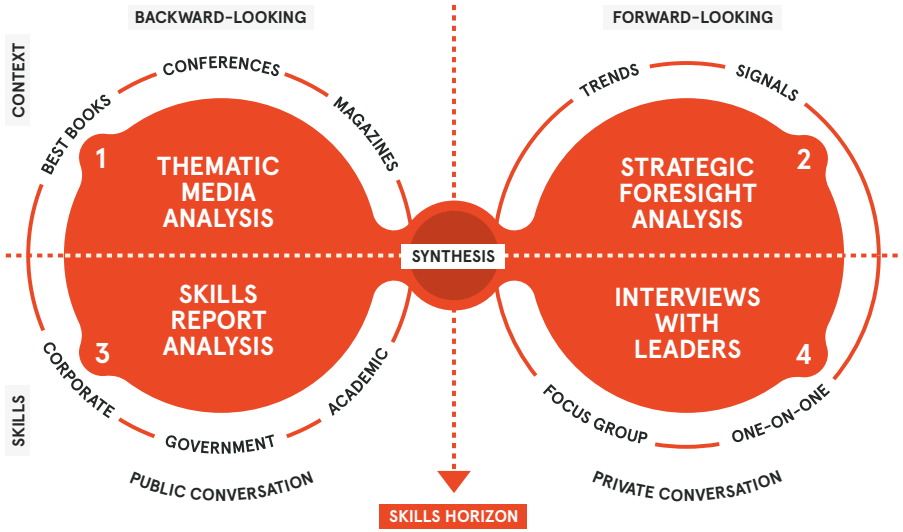
We bring these three dimensions together in four interrelated studies, from which we've synthesised the Skills Horizon and the detailed skill outlines presented in this report:

01 THEMATIC MEDIA ANALYSIS

To map how the world is changing, and what the big developments are that shape society and the economy, we built a corpus of data featuring key future-focused publications and conferences. We then applied topic modelling, thematic analysis, and frequency analysis techniques to understand the topics that stood out from these public conversations over time.

02 STRATEGIC FORESIGHT ANALYSIS

Our research team uses a set of strategic foresight methods to track and trace emerging trends and early signals to anticipate possible futures. We combine the use of well-known megatrends with signals analysis and scenarios to gain an understanding of how the world is changing. When complemented with insights from our senior leader interviews, our foresight work provides the narrative presented in the introduction to this report.



03 DESK RESEARCH ON SKILLS

We reviewed more than 50 reports—on the future of work and skills, as well as those exploring key trends impacting organisations, business, and leadership.

These reports feature significant inputs from management consulting firms, global bodies like the World Economic Forum, large corporates like Microsoft, plus government publications and academic research. While reports rarely address skills needs for leaders and executives directly (focusing instead on the broader workforce), this research provides important context for leadership skills.

04 SENIOR LEADER INTERVIEWS

Gaining insight into the private worlds and thoughts of leaders is more challenging, as it involves bringing conversations that happen organically to the surface.

At the core of our study are personal interviews and focus group sessions with senior leaders and executives in business, government, academia, defence, culture, and the arts. Among others, we spoke with CEOs, CPOs, former prime ministers, army generals, government secretaries, NGO and charity leaders, head chefs, tech leaders, airline captains, judges, and arts executives from around the globe.

We asked what they saw impacting their respective organisations over the next decade and what skills they thought leaders would need in our changing world.

The world in words

"The skill that is so difficult, that so many people don't have, is that -when data works, just use data, get more data, do experiments. But for some questions, there are too many relevant factors to collect data. Then use judgement."

Dan Clancy
CEO, Twitch

This is a behind-the-scenes look at how we identified and analysed the public conversation. We built a corpus that includes the metadata for a number of future-focused outlets (for the period 2020-2025), which allowed us to answer two big questions:

WHAT'S EVERYBODY READING?

Best Business Books of the Year lists help us to see what's exciting everybody. Books take a while to write and publish, but they can have a big impact on the public conversation. Best books lists give us a good sense of where the conversation is coming from and where it might be going.

Harvard Business Review and *The World Ahead* (from *The Economist*) are faster than a book, but slower than the news cycle. They give us a sense of what's happening when you've got a finger on the economy's pulse.

WHAT'S EVERYBODY TALKING ABOUT?

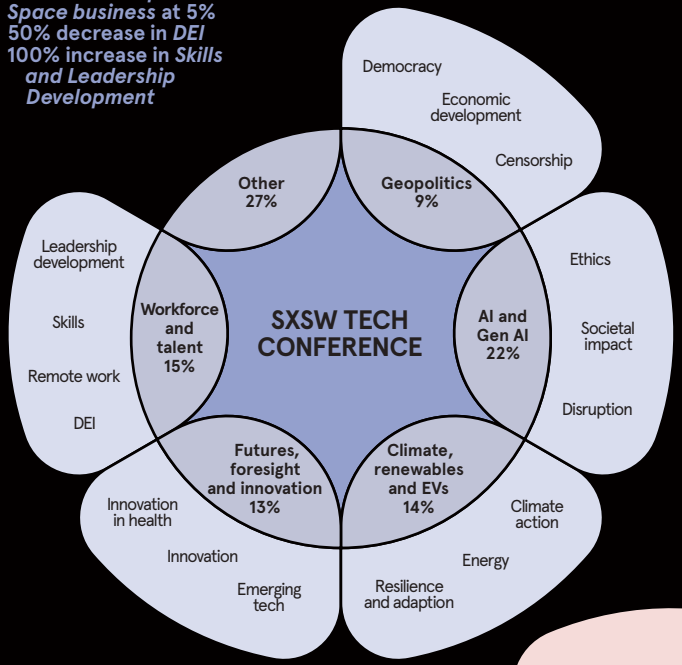
If you want to get a feel for the future, there are two big conferences that help.

World leaders meet in Davos every year for the World Economic Forum to discuss big changes ahead—as they happen and as they make them. And every March, the who's who of tech, media, and the arts flock to Austin (TX) for SXSW to reveal the future, as driven by technology, culture, and media.

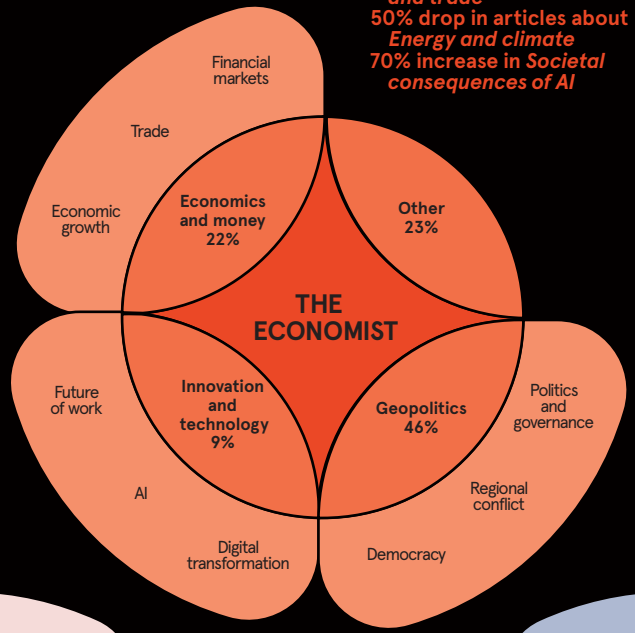
For the analysis, we did as we teach—we employed AI. We used large language models (LLMs) for topic modelling across a sample of these five outlets. We used TopicGPT, a prompt-based, topic modelling framework to identify the topics and sub-topics that characterise the conversation. Frequency analysis gave us percentages. We present the top topics for each outlet, and some of the standout insights.

+ Mapping the public conversation

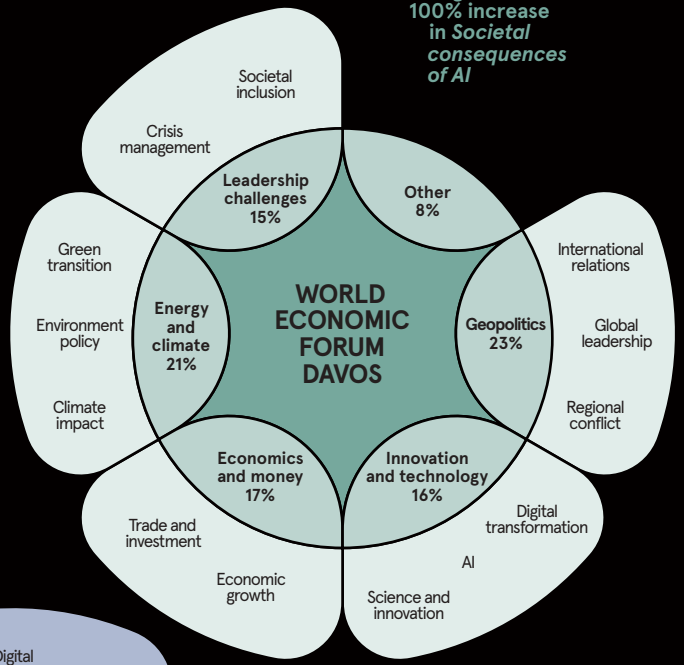
70% increase in *AI market disruption*
Space business at 5%
50% decrease in *DEI*
100% increase in *Skills and Leadership Development*



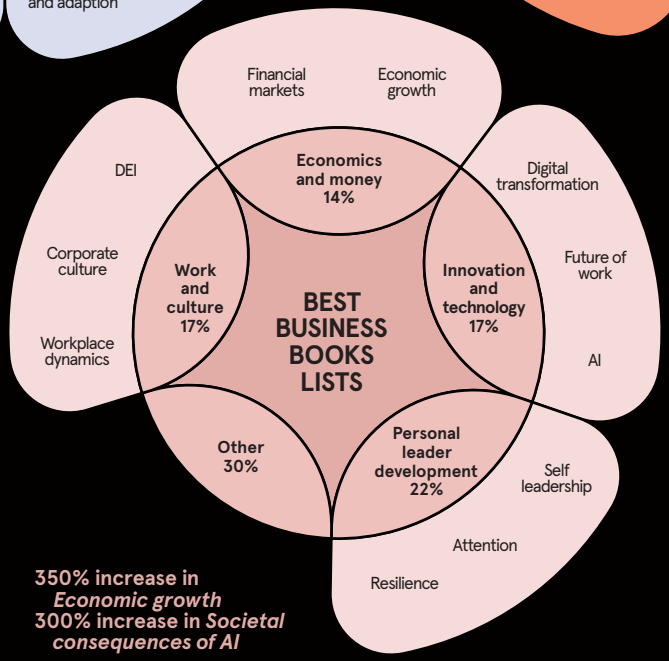
50% increase in *International relations and trade*
50% drop in articles about *Energy and climate*
70% increase in *Societal consequences of AI*



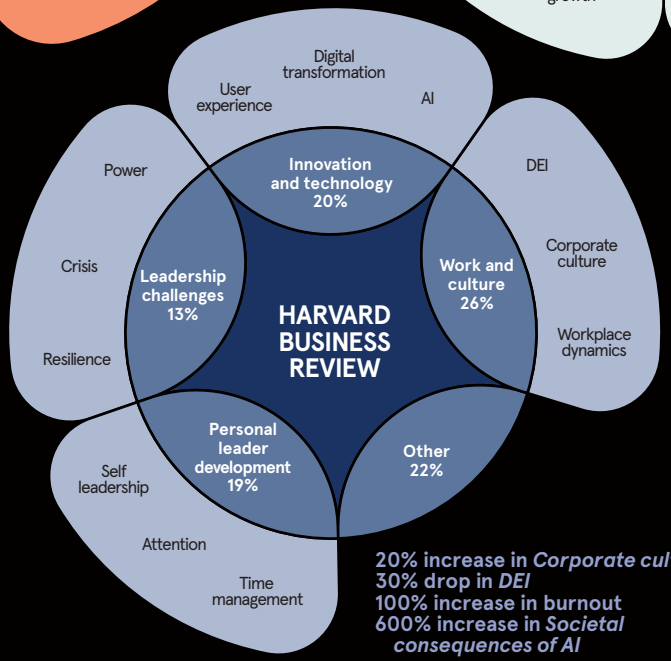
300% increase in *Regional conflict*
100% increase in *Societal consequences of AI*



Reaching peak hype in AI: 25% of proposed session titles for SXSW 2026 reference AI. 63% mention it in the description.



350% increase in *Economic growth*
300% increase in *Societal consequences of AI*



Societal consequences of AI is the topic with the strongest increase across publications–highlighting the ethics of AI and AI's impact on jobs and human identity. There is also a noticeable dampening of *DEI* and *Climate* conversations.

20% increase in *Corporate culture*
30% drop in *DEI*
100% increase in burnout
600% increase in *Societal consequences of AI*

All topic distributions measured across 5 years: 2020–2024 for publications, 2021–2025 for conferences.
For SXSW, we focused on the tech track of the conference.
All % changes measured over the most recent 2-year period.

How to use the Skills Horizon

Think of the Skills Horizon as a dynamic guide to help you and your team stay prepared for what's ahead. It should always be read in the context of our changing world, along with the work you do and your career trajectory.

THE SKILLS HORIZON WILL HELP YOU TO:

- Strategically plan and track what skills you need to acquire or hone now, what you need to learn next, and what you might explore and experiment with.
- Create a shared vocabulary with your team.
- Evaluate and understand your, and your team's, skills.
- Feed insights into broader strategy processes.
- Prioritise professional learning and development actions by considering timing, resource implications, and integration into individual development plans and performance reviews. This is crucial in preparing the next generation of leaders in your organisation.
- Promote a leadership culture that fosters continuous learning. And encourage team members to do the same.
- Impress people at dinner parties. If you think oysters are popular, you should see the attention a story about managing for stability gets.

Build a skills-based learning organisation

Leadership development happens at the intersection of skills and capabilities. Horizon skills complement and amplify capabilities and expertise gained from formative education and hands-on experience. They allow you and your organisation to deal with Shifts and Clashes, to find traction in headwinds, and new ideas in fractures.

Where individuals see opportunities for lifelong learning, L&D professionals gain insights for crafting a lasting learning culture for their organisation. The Skills Horizon becomes your instrument for creating deliberate upskilling initiatives that will equip your leaders to adapt and lead with confidence, and socialise skills across your cohorts of emerging leaders.

Skills-based leadership development deepens your organisation's responsiveness to change, diversifies your knowledge capital, and cascades resilience to your whole team. Rather than trying to extract more with existing skills, a deeper skills base enables you to create new value.

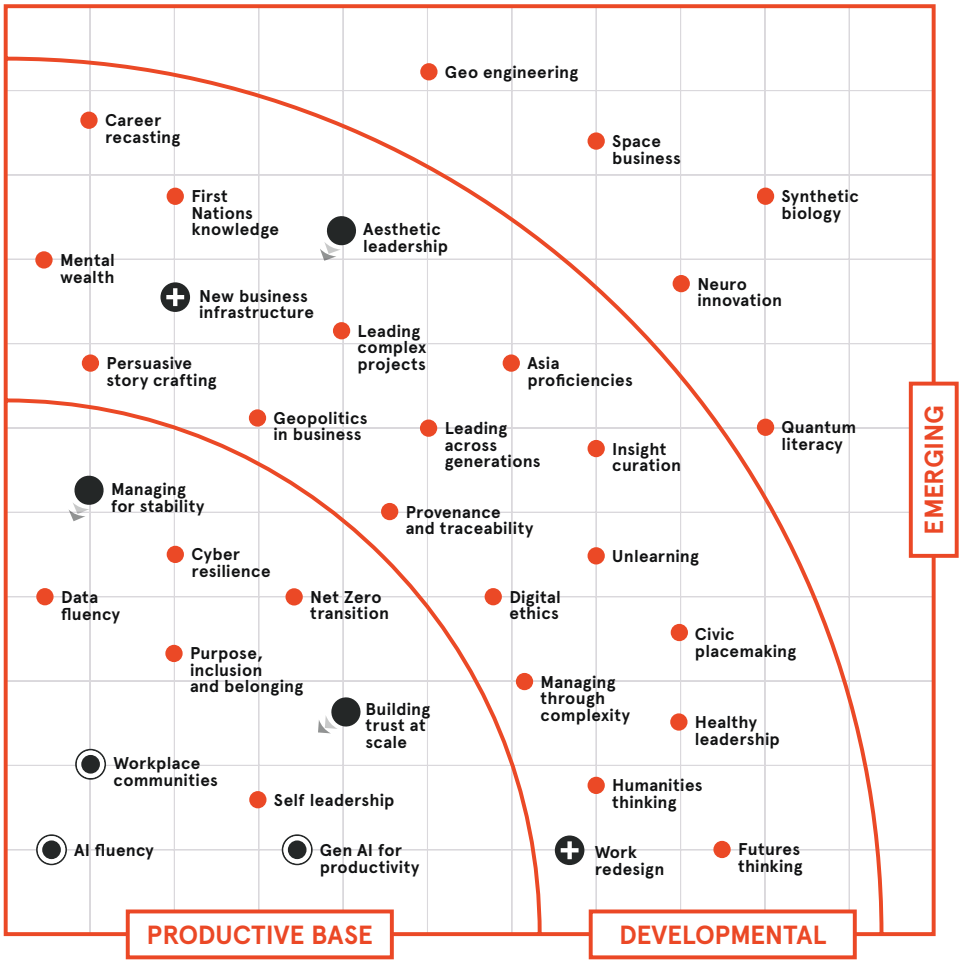
We've identified four practices that can get you started on the journey:

01 CLASH LABS
Bring your executive team together for short focus sessions on one or two Clashes. Explore how these Clashes are playing out for your organisation to gain insights on where preparation is needed.

02 SKILLS MAPPING
Use the Skills Horizon to take stock. Map your leaders' and teams' preparedness against the skills across the three horizons. Grade skills for criticality and impact against your own strategic priorities.

03 HORIZON UPDATES
The Skills Horizon is designed to drive your L&D strategy, but strategy isn't set and forget: it's a living process. Ask your team to track your organisation's skills depth against the Skills Horizon with quarterly updates.

04 THE ECOSYSTEM PLAY
You aren't building these skills alone: you're working alongside partners, vendors, and clients. Make upskilling conversations a part of these relationships, deepening your connection and building capability together to strengthen your ecosystem.



The 2026

Skills Horizon

What skills do leaders need in a decade of disorientation?

We've plotted the knowledge and tools you need to lead on the Skills Horizon.

But where do you start? And, as many things compete and change and clash, how do you choose where to focus?

During our research, some skills stood out from the pack. We noticed three kinds of interesting moves that deserve special attention: **Amplifiers**, **Movers**, and **Unexpected Emergers**. Over the next few pages, we explore what they are and why they matter.

As the world changes, so do the skills you need to keep a close eye on. Get to know your Amplifiers, Movers, and Unexpected Emergers.

Amplifiers

> "There is still a lot of ignorance when it comes to AI and technology in part of the corporate sector. Companies risk missing out on the benefits, but also, lack awareness when it comes to the impact on jobs and their overall business model."
>
> **Dragoș Tudorache**
> Member of the European Parliament
> and Chair of the Special Committee on AI

These skills need your urgent attention. They're performance-enhancers that boost the existing capabilities and skills within your organisation.

AI fluency

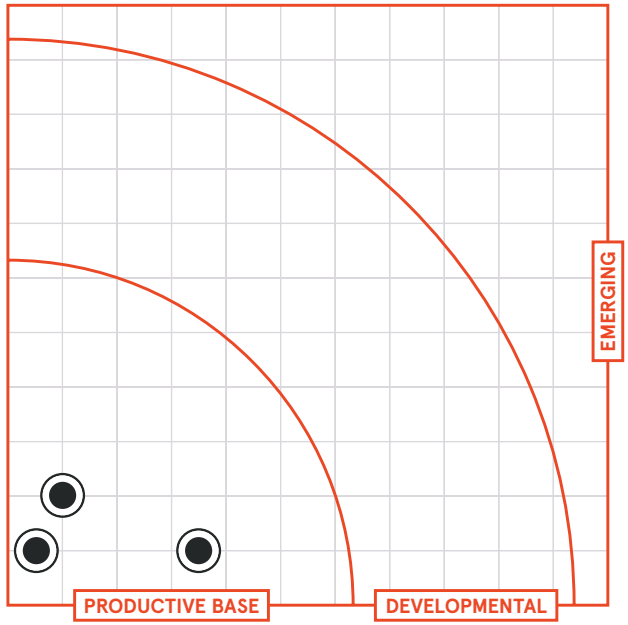
This is the ability to understand, engage with, and leverage artificial intelligence technologies for your organisation. You don't need to code, but as a leader, you need to know the technology deeply enough to make informed decisions—whether that's around the alignment of AI with strategic objectives or its impacts on work and people.

As a general-purpose technology, AI will soon touch everything. **AI fluency** as a skill interacts with and amplifies many other skills. Speaking the language of AI is now a critical skill for effective leaders.

Gen AI for productivity

As a forward-thinking leader, you need to know what Gen AI can do for you. You need to understand how it works, its limitations, how to prompt effectively, and how your use fits in with your wider teams. This takes a creative experimentation mindset and an openness to sharing best practice use cases.

Get it wrong and productivity can go backwards. Get it right and **Gen AI** will be an amplifier for both your own and your teams' performance.



> **"The premium on 'humanity' in business is only set to climb. Most of us are in the people business after all, and we should never forget that. Great technology supports great people, not the other way around."**
>
> **Justin D'Agostino**
> Global CEO, Herbert Smith Freehills Kramer

Workplace communities

You and your leadership team need to learn how to find and maintain balance between flexibility and complexity. Flexibility increases individual productivity and attracts talent, but it also drives complexity at the system level. When people are dispersed and work at different times, the coordination costs are borne by your leadership team.

Your focus will need to be on facilitating **Workplace communities**, enabled by tech, that can function regardless of how and where they work. As such, this becomes an Amplifier for you and your teams.

WORKING IN PARIS

Every mode of working has its benefits and weaknesses. To make remote and hybrid work for you, consider what goes missing when we no longer share the same space.

Social capital—the invisible web of relationships and shared understandings that makes teams tick—often emerges as a byproduct of working together physically. We bump into each other, have casual chats, see when someone needs help, or pick up a piece of news we would otherwise have missed.

In remote settings, social capital requires your explicit attention. In our experience, the solution can be found in PARIS (also a great remote work location): five critical functions that you can foster intentionally so your people develop the shared fabric of a productive team.

P **Problem-solving:** Facilitate rapid-help channels and expert "office hours" so people don't get stuck with problems waiting for scheduled meetings.

A **Apprenticeships:** Formalise what was once informal learning—record key meetings, have senior staff share their thinking, have official coaching arrangements.

R **Relationships:** Build trust deliberately through non-work interactions, meaningful check-ins, and strategic coffee chats. And bring people together regularly.

I **Information discovery:** Recreate serendipity by sharing broader context, encouraging "thinking out loud" in shared online spaces, and cross-pollinating insights.

S **Sensemaking:** Invest in collective understanding through regular "what does this mean for us?" sessions and cross-team perspective sharing.

Movers

> "External forces are coming in through compliance and are forcing a change in behaviour and trust between organisations."
>
> **Laszlo Peter**
> CEO, OriginsNext

These skills have shifted in importance and shape. Their prominence has come in response to global trends and social change.

Managing for stability

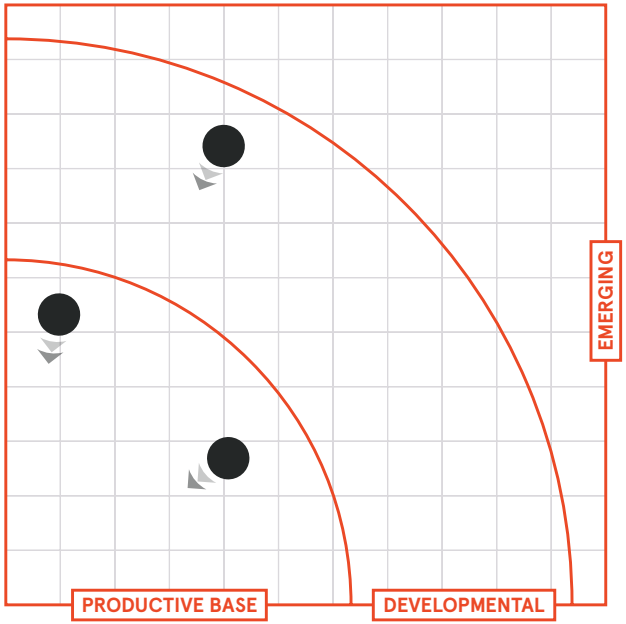
The amount of change from technology, geopolitical disruption, and shifts in values has hit a tipping point. When everything around shifts and clashes, your team needs one constant—you.

Managing for stability is your ability to manage change and transformation in ways that absorb external complexity and create the calm your team needs to function. It's about leadership as an anchor: establishing psychological safety that allows your team to tackle difficult work without fear of failure with the necessary transformations ahead.

Building trust at scale

Public trust in leaders is at an all-time low. This requires your involvement *more*, not less. In a world where AI slop and populism erode shared facts and your credibility (along with that of your fellow leaders), **Building trust at scale** is rapidly becoming a critical enabler for your organisation.

This skill involves taking an active role in strengthening the networks of trust that your industry and business depend on. It requires engagement with policymakers, clear communication in messy public environments, and genuine follow-through on commitments.



"To be authentic, leaders need to have different emphasis for different stakeholders, but have one consistent message across all contexts. Leaders need to be honest about where the challenges are and practical about what they are actually going to do, not just make promises."

Frank Calabria
CEO & MD, Origin Energy

Aesthetic leadership

What kind of leader will you be, when nothing feels certain, when information drowns in noise, and demands on your attention mount? Aesthetic leadership is your ability to discern, judge and make choices, and communicate in contextually effective ways. It's about form—being effective and memorable without compromising substance.

Aesthetic leadership isn't about charisma (though charm can be a part of it)—it's your ability to lead with empathy, to project yourself into diverse situations (both online and in person), to articulate messages in clear and accessible ways. As such, you must find balance, adapting to contexts without fracturing the coherence of your persona.

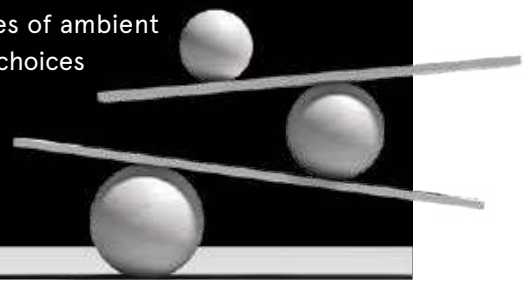
CHOOSING OURSELVES TO DEATH?

You probably know the feeling. You're on the couch after a long day, your streaming service has curated recommendations for you, and you spend an hour watching trailers, trying to decide.

Our technology breeds an abundance of choice–the very choice it then promises to help us with. Algorithms fill our news feeds, suggest dinner options, recommend what we will watch. And yet, here we are, often paralysed and unable to choose. Consumers on average spend 150 mins a week deciding what to eat and 50 mins on what to watch (Galloway 2024).

Algorithms are meant to help. They learn our preferences, then offer us relevant options and suggestions. Quick and easy. Should we just let them make our choices for us? We could do, but where does it end? The more we leave it up to algorithms, the more we might lose the ability to choose.

How are we going to hone our taste and judgement when algorithms promise to handle more and more decisions for us? In allowing them to do so, we avoid the care and consideration that builds the muscle to make good choices in the first place. Remember: in times of ambient uncertainty, making good choices is more important than ever for leaders.



Unexpected emergers

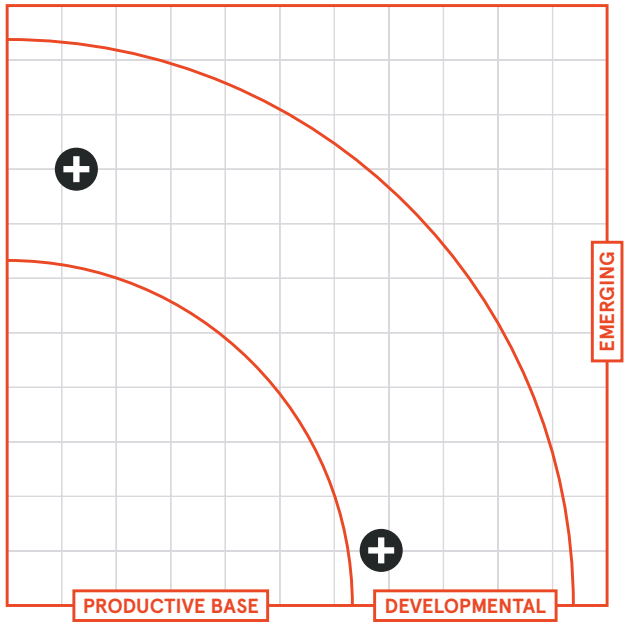
> "The needs of data centres, what they are, what they can do, is very much invisible to the majority of leaders. We absolutely need to talk about energy efficiency from a domestic point of view, and from a business point of view."
>
> **Bernadette Foley**
> Acting Chief Engineer, Engineers Australia

These skills are the new wildcards, brought about by changing circumstances. If applied effectively, they'll allow you to capitalise on big (and sometimes surprising) opportunities.

New business infrastructure

What you once learnt about how the economy works is rapidly becoming outdated. Today, the economy lives and works in data centres: massive investment and energy hungry infrastructure that powers the way we interact, transact, and make decisions.

Did you know that the capacity of data centres is measured in energy units? Do you understand the ways in which the energy grid is changing to accommodate both our digital growth and our transition away from hydrocarbons? Do you understand your dependencies, risk, and cost exposure from these transitions? Not to mention the untapped opportunities. Effective leaders will benefit from understanding the **New business infrastructure** powering our economy.



> **"The biggest thing that needs to change is how we lead and how we work as humans. I don't think we've evolved how we operate to keep up with the potential of the technology and we're trying to impersonate a digital world from an analogue mindset."**

Dom Price
Former Work Futurist, Atlassian

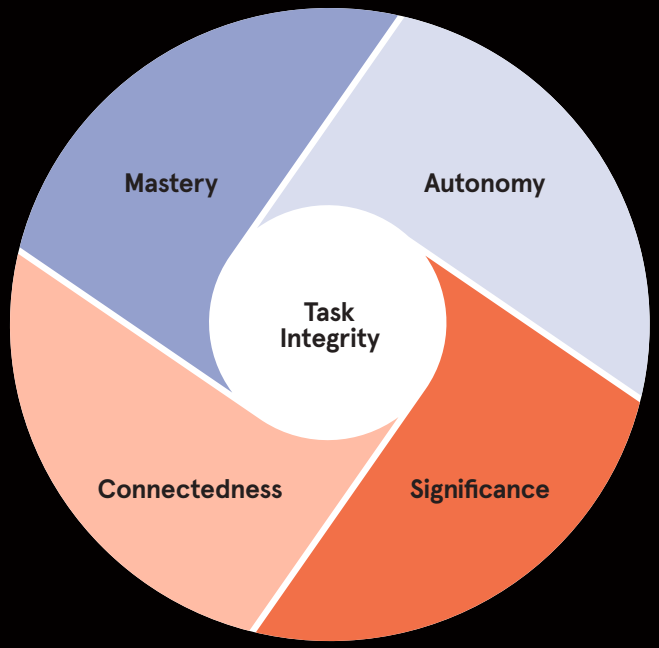
Work redesign

This skill has emerged much faster than expected. The speed of AI, changing generational values, and fracturing information environments require rethinking the way we work, beyond the individual and team levels, for your entire workforce.

How will you make productivity effects from AI stick? How will you craft effective teams, enabled by AI and digital tools? How will you craft effective information practices? What will the future shape of your workforce look like when entry-level jobs will be absorbed by AI use? What will careers, KPIs, and work roles look like? **Work redesign** means balancing automation with human expertise—finding new productivity gains at the system level. Keep an eye out, as this may soon be a crucial leadership skill.

THE FIVE ELEMENTS OF MEANINGFUL WORK

Years of research have shown that your team does their best work when work is meaningful (so do you, by the way). But what is meaningful work? Our research shows that it's made up of five key elements:



- **TASK INTEGRITY:** your tasks should be part of a coherent whole.
- **MASTERY:** you are using and improving your skills.
- **AUTONOMY:** you have a sense of direction and control.
- **SIGNIFICANCE:** your work matters to your organisation, and the world.
- **CONNECTEDNESS:** your work connects you with other people.

Creating meaningful work in the age of AI and hybrid work requires your attention. Building tech fluency, investing in culture and productive work communities, and redesigning your work system should proceed with these elements in mind.

The final frontier

"There will be massive changes in the next 10 years in technology, in bio tech, new material development, especially once quantum hits."

The Hon. Victor Dominello
CEO, Future Government Institute

"Space is a frontier that has the potential to move us from a world of scarcity to one of abundance."

David Hill
CEO, Deloitte Asia Pacific

DAWN OF THE QUANTUM AGE

2025 was the United Nations' International Year of Quantum Science and Technology. Quantum as a field is growing fast: investment in the tech increased by 125% year-on-year (Market Research, 2025).

But 2025 is just one step in a longer journey. The next few years will likely see quantum technologies go big (even though the quantum bits are very small).

Quantum leaders like IBM, Google, and Microsoft have started deploying quantum on the cloud. This means your business can start experimenting with ways to innovate with quantum computing today.

At the very least you want to start preparing—by learning more about it. Quantum technologies are going to be disruptive, rather than incremental. The moment we'll have functioning quantum computing at scale will be a watershed for IT security—traditional encryption will break. It's time to think about quantum safety and quantum preparedness.

Forward-thinking boards and leaders are already considering how to develop their **Quantum literacy.**

THERE'S A STARMAN WAITING IN THE SKY...

Space business is getting real. With private players like SpaceX, Blue Origin, and New Zealand's Rocket Lab competing to drive down launch costs, it's never been cheaper to send a commercial payload into orbit. In 2024, the global space economy was worth $613bn (Space Foundation 2025).

But space business doesn't just happen in orbit–it has strong implications for your earthside operations. Consider the availability of high-speed satellite Internet anywhere on the planet. With competition between Starlink and Amazon's Project Kuiper (ABC 2025), your customers, communities, and colleagues can now truly connect from anywhere. And easy access to satellite capacity, imagery, and data services provides new opportunities for location-based AI products.

Building space capability is quickly becoming reality for any business. This raises new questions around tech fluency, competition, capability building, dependencies, and risk. All the way back in 2022, the *Harvard Business Review* said you needed a space strategy (HBR 2022). Do you have one yet?

There are areas of convergence in the skills you need to know next.
We still call them Blobs.

The shape of things to come

The skills you need next, in four Blobs

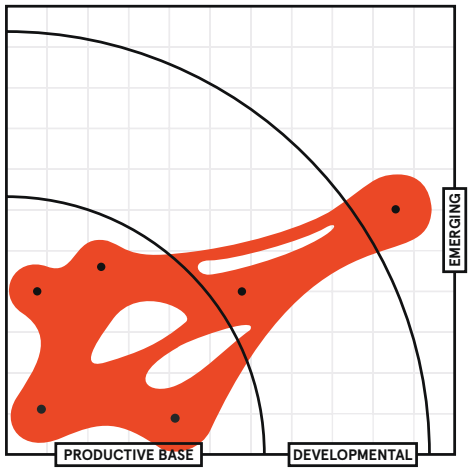
Why Blobs? We called them that because... that's what they look like. Sometimes it's best not to overthink things.

Our quartet of Blobs play an important role in thinking about leadership upskilling. They visually embody how skills converge around key topics and perspectives that are relevant to your leadership journey and your organisation's future.

These areas of convergence are: technology and its implications, large-scale challenges in the external environment, people and workplace issues, and the complexity and uncertainty that you yourself face as a leader. You'll need to learn new things in each of these areas.

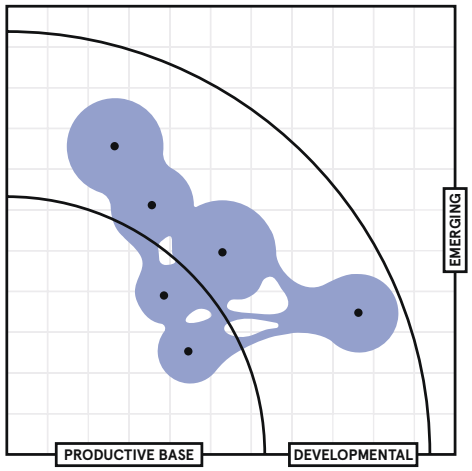
BLOB 1

Speaking the language of tech



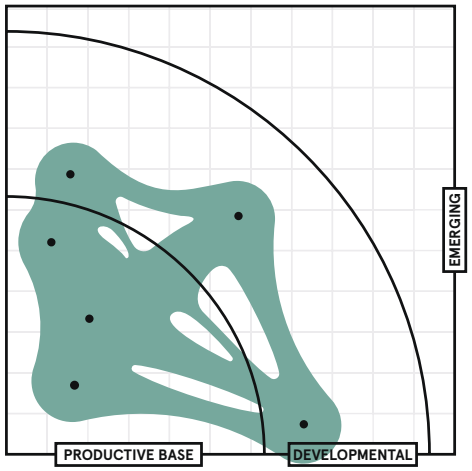
BLOB 2

Solving problems of scale



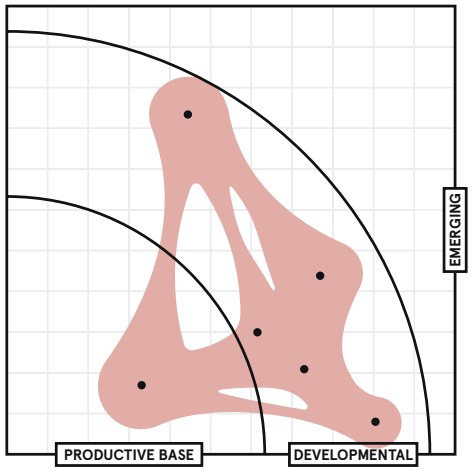
BLOB 3

Working across difference



BLOB 4

Thinking through complexity



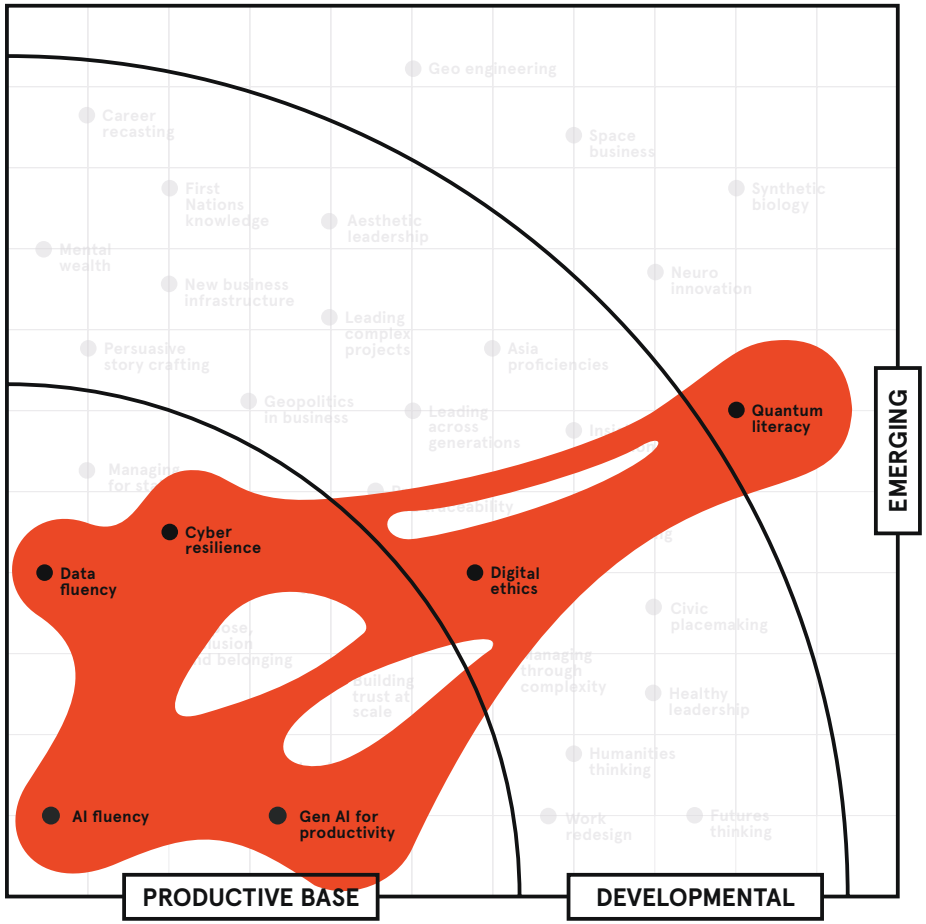
“Technology is a fundamental part of achieving strategy and every leader needs to be able to understand how to use it in their business.”

Vicki Brady
CEO, Telstra

BLOB 1

Speaking the language of tech

You need to make it work



Last year we told you that you can't fake it anymore: you need to speak the language of tech and be fluent in AI.

This year you're faced with the tech-productivity puzzle. Now that AI has arrived in your organisation and made its presence felt at every level, you need to make it work—for you, your team, and across your business.

While productivity is the goal, transformation is the means. A 'just add AI' approach isn't fit for purpose and isn't a strategy. The solution instead lies in new knowledge, thoughtful implementation, and informed experimentation. And don't forget about your people. We're all in R&D now, with access to the same tools, so your people and their expertise will be the true differentiator.

Data, digital ethics, and cyber resilience are vital enablers in helping you crack the tech-productivity puzzle. Quantum might just be the next enabler, so it's worth getting across that too.

AI IS HERE. PUT IT TO WORK.

Whether you're ready or not, your people are using AI. And that's fair enough. These tools help them to be faster and more creative, so why wait for permission or guidelines?

A recent Microsoft (2024) study shows that 78% of workers are bringing their own AI tools to work, and it's not just younger ones. Pretending this isn't the case, or not providing approved tools, has fast become the irresponsible position. Your options? Let it happen or make it work.

"How you measure productivity in the new world will be a challenge as the ways of working change."

Lynette Sarno
Chief People Officer, Macquarie Group

"To prepare for AI transformation, set AI challenges for your business and your leaders. Get them to figure out a problem with AI, improve something, report back and share their solution."

Chris Crosby
CEO, Compass Datacenters

"When you are preparing for a monthly meeting, suspend your scepticism, give it [AI] some basic facts and ask, 'What questions should we discuss at our monthly meeting?'"

Guy Kawasaki
Chief Evangelist, Canva

"It will increasingly be important to create an AI-ready organisation. Rather than, 'Can AI solve this problem?', how can you set up the organisation so it can make use of AI, formulate business problems so that AI can help—what data you collect, how you create value—in a way so that machine learning can solve that for you."

Michael Spranger
President, Sony AI, COO, Sony Research

"We need 'Hollywood reform'. What I mean by that is finding and creating stories that show AI helping peoples' lives, not pitting AI against humans."

Wilson White
Vice President, Government Affairs & Public Policy, Google

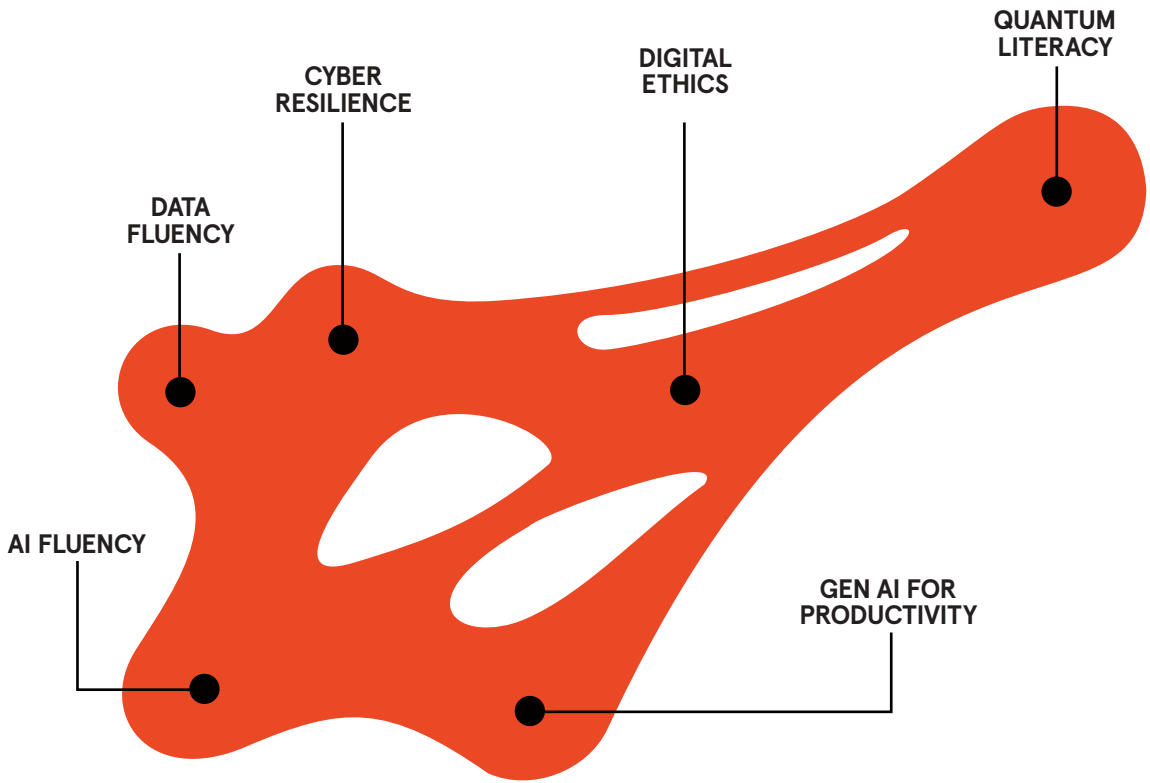
"We lead a lot with technology and tools. We sometimes forget about the human. There has to be a role for articulating and defining and advocating for the human."

Kiersten Robinson
Chief People Officer, Commonwealth Bank

"There is a profound issue with privacy and security when AI performs tasks on users' behalf. It would need to be able to drive that process across entire systems."

Meredith Whittaker
President of Signal

BLOB 1 SPEAKING THE LANGUAGE OF TECH



The same research found that 52% of those using AI don't admit they're using it for core tasks, for fear of being judged. If you want to reap its benefits, AI use needs to emerge from the shadows into the light. Make it a normal, celebrated part of work rather than something people do in secret.

ADAPT, DON'T JUST ADOPT

Here's the thing about making it work, though: AI investments won't magically turn into productivity gains. Just ask anyone who lived through the computer revolution of the 1980s. Sprinkling new technology on old ways of working often leads to expensive disappointment.

Early findings on AI-assisted productivity are mixed. While some recent research shows a 66% increase in employee productivity from Gen AI tools (WEF 2025), a survey of 2,500 professionals found workload actually increased for 77% of workers (Upwork 2024). Nearly half said they didn't know how to unlock productivity. But benefits aren't evenly distributed either. Some research suggests lower-skilled workers catch up with AI's help (MIT Sloan 2023). Yet, many leaders tell us that senior workers benefit more because they're better at judging when AI outputs are useful versus when they need revision. Juniors might struggle when left without coaching.

Sound familiar? During the computer revolution, we learnt that IT benefits were very unevenly spread. Where IT was actively managed and not just bolted onto old processes, productivity improved. The lesson is clear: AI needs your involvement. And don't just adopt—adapt. It's not enough to introduce new tech and hope your people figure it out. You need to contextualise AI for your organisation, experiment deliberately, and scale what works.

INVEST IN TECH AND TEAM

In a world full of AI, your people will be the difference.

When everyone has access to the same tools, human expertise and experience, knowing what questions to ask, what outputs to trust, and how to contextualise results becomes the real advantage. Yes, AI is a powerful tool, but it works differently to humans. Treat it as such, to amplify your people. Don't think of it in terms of 'AI versus people', which is limiting and can understandably make the team nervous.

Make no mistake, jobs will change. And some will be needed in lower numbers. AI will affect entry-level roles (Stanford 2025), at least in the near

The skills in this Blob

+ AI FLUENCY

The ability to understand the nature, capabilities, and challenges of (generative) AI; converse confidently with AI stakeholders; and guide the strategic development of AI use cases and decisions for their operational implementation.

+ GEN AI FOR PRODUCTIVITY

The ability to employ and harness Gen AI tools practically and effectively, in your own (and your team's) work practices, to lift productivity. Extend the use of Gen AI systems beyond simple prompting to comprehensive use cases.

+ DATA FLUENCY

An understanding of the importance and nature of data as an asset and as material in transformation and decision-making. The ability to audit internal and external data sources and appreciate their strategic value and bottom-line impact.

+ DIGITAL ETHICS

The ability to navigate complex ethical considerations of digital technologies, data use, and algorithmic decision; identify potential risks; and devise strategies to ensure that practices align with organisational values and societal norms.

+ CYBER RESILIENCE

A foundational understanding of cybersecurity and data privacy; the ability to identify risks, threats, and measures to protect digital assets; and preparedness to organise and communicate effectively to recover from inevitable incidents.

+ QUANTUM LITERACY

An understanding of the basic principles and potential applications of quantum technologies. The ability to stay informed about the latest developments in quantum science, to assess their feasibility and identify early use cases and strategic value.

term, while senior workers using AI become more effective. But how will you then develop that senior expertise? Capability building requires your attention. And it requires you to invest in both AI *and* people.

Now's the time to complement AI fluency—your knowledge of what AI can do for your organisation—with AI dexterity, the practical know-how of making it productive for yourself and for everyone in your organisation. By combining these skills, you can achieve the quest for productivity and efficiency without compromising your organisation's capability and expertise.

EVERYTHING'S CONNECTED

With your mind firmly on productivity and ROI, it can be easy to forget how all the tech pieces fit together, interact, and evolve in your organisation.

AI is more than chatbots, and its effects go beyond productivity. AI's transformative effects might reshape your entire industry. This will happen more slowly but will also hit harder. It's best to think of your AI journey as happening in two lanes: immediate productivity gains and long-term transformation. You need both.

Remember that every AI conversation is also a data conversation. And every data conversation raises digital ethics and cybersecurity questions. These aren't separate matters, they're interconnected foundations.

On the security front, cyberattacks aren't just risks anymore—they're 'whens', not 'ifs'. They've become inevitable, made more likely in a world of AI. You'll be judged not just on prevention, but also on response and recovery, so your focus must shift to cyber resilience. Your final consideration is the quantum question. Are your operations quantum-safe? When quantum computing eventually breaks current computing, will your security hold?

+ Speaking the language of tech, in numbers

HIGH AI EXPECTATIONS

96%

of leaders expect Gen AI will boost worker productivity; 39% already demand its use (Upwork 2024)

AI LONG-TERM OPPORTUNITY

$4.4TN

in added productivity growth potential from AI (McKinsey 2025a)

AI CAN SAVE WORKERS TIME

90%

of AI users in one study say they save time; 84% are more creative (Microsoft 2024a)

AI CAN INCREASE WORKLOAD

77%

of AI users across US, UK, Australia, and Canada say the tech has added to their workload (Upwork 2024)

DIRECTION FOR AI IS UNCLEAR

60%

of leaders worry that they have no plan or direction for how to implement AI (Microsoft 2024)

AI AFFECTS ENTRY-LEVEL WORK

69%

of Australian executives say AI will absorb entry-level work (SMH 2025)

UNDERGROUND AI IS REAL

78%

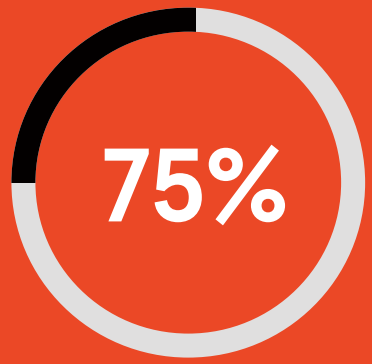
of AI users across organisations of all sizes bring their own tools to work (BYOAI) (Microsoft 2024)

AI MATURITY IS LOW

1%

of leaders state that their company is “mature” in AI (McKinsey 2025)

AI UPSKILLING IS NEEDED



of Australian businesses struggle to find the AI talent they need (KBI 2025)

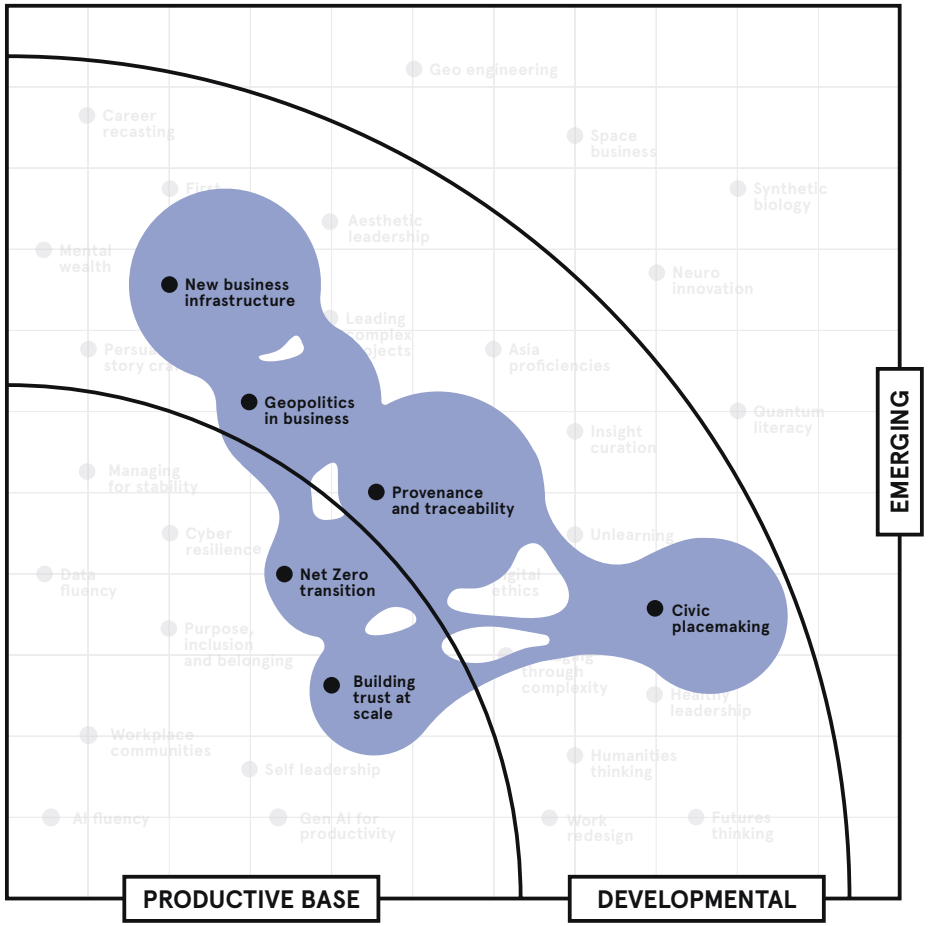
"A theme for big business has been a loss of agency and a loss of social license. There is an overarching atmosphere of caution and a kind of strategic conservatism. Being bold is difficult. It becomes really tricky to be adventurous in the way you communicate, in the way you project your brand and your values."

James Chessell
Editor-in-Chief, The Australian Financial Review

BLOB 2

Solving problems of scale

You need to trust and be trusted



It's challenging enough to build, retain, and scale trust at the best of times. In our complex and uncertain world, you need to nurture *two* forms of trust: 1) the trust your network has in you, and 2) the trust you have in your network.

With trust in business and leaders at an all-time low, there's pressure to maintain the goodwill of your various audiences and communities. And as stakeholders and regulators demand confidence in your data, you need to evolve accountability at scale, right across your value chain.

Then there's the matter of scaling your own trust. As global orders fracture and supply chains wobble, you need to create trusted partner ecosystems. Meanwhile, a new business infrastructure is taking shape. As you look to scale your capabilities, the need to find trust in your external dependencies will only grow.

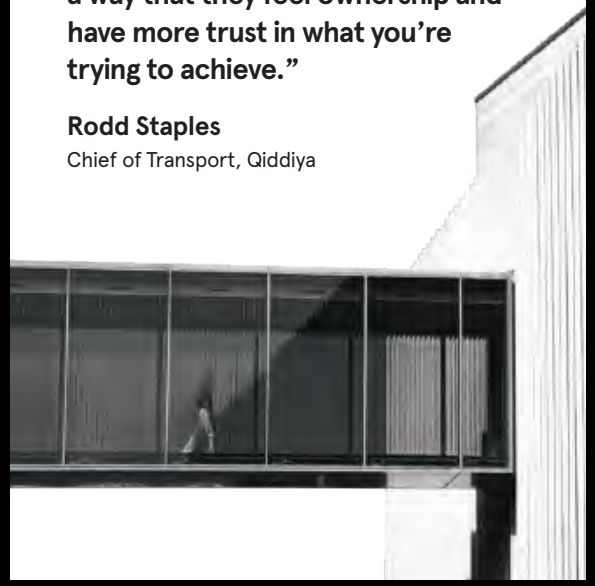
WITH GREAT TRUST COMES GREAT RESPONSIBILITY

Trust in leaders has hit rock bottom. Globally, 68% of respondents say business leaders "purposely mislead people", up 12 points since 2021. Government leaders fare no better at 69%, up 11 points (Edelman 2025).

Behind this mistrust lies a growing sense of injustice. 61% of respondents hold grievances, convinced the system is stacked against them. For this group, business and government leaders aren't just untrustworthy, they're seen as 81 points less ethical and 37 points

"The sense of inequity that washes through the community tends to be quite polarising. People feel like they're losing. You need to co-create with customers and communities in a way that they feel ownership and have more trust in what you're trying to achieve."

Rodd Staples
Chief of Transport, Qiddiya



"We have no common ground. We need to create common ground. It's important to have tools of communication that create civic infrastructure, storytelling for common ground."

Jacqui Feeney
CEO, Screen Queensland

"In terms of your credibility with broader stakeholders and the public, what is really important is not so much the promise as the delivery. It used to be all about the strategy. Today, credibility comes from actually delivering on a promise, and the transparency that you bring to a problem."

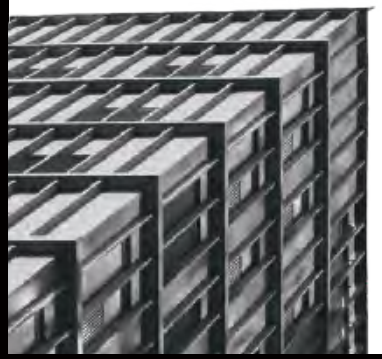
Mike Fuge
CEO, Contact Energy

"Customer trust is earned by doing things well every single day, not big brand campaigns. It comes both from your capabilities, and from the character of the organisation, that they see you stand for something and have their interests at heart."

Frank Calabria
CEO & MD, Origin Energy

"One of the key things that businesses are really going to grapple with over the next five years is coming to terms with social license as a really critical currency."

Eamon Waterford
CEO, Committee for Sydney

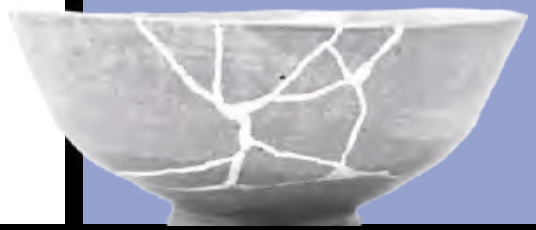


"The responsibility of a brand or company wanting to connect more authentically with their audiences doesn't sit exclusively with marketing or with the CMO."

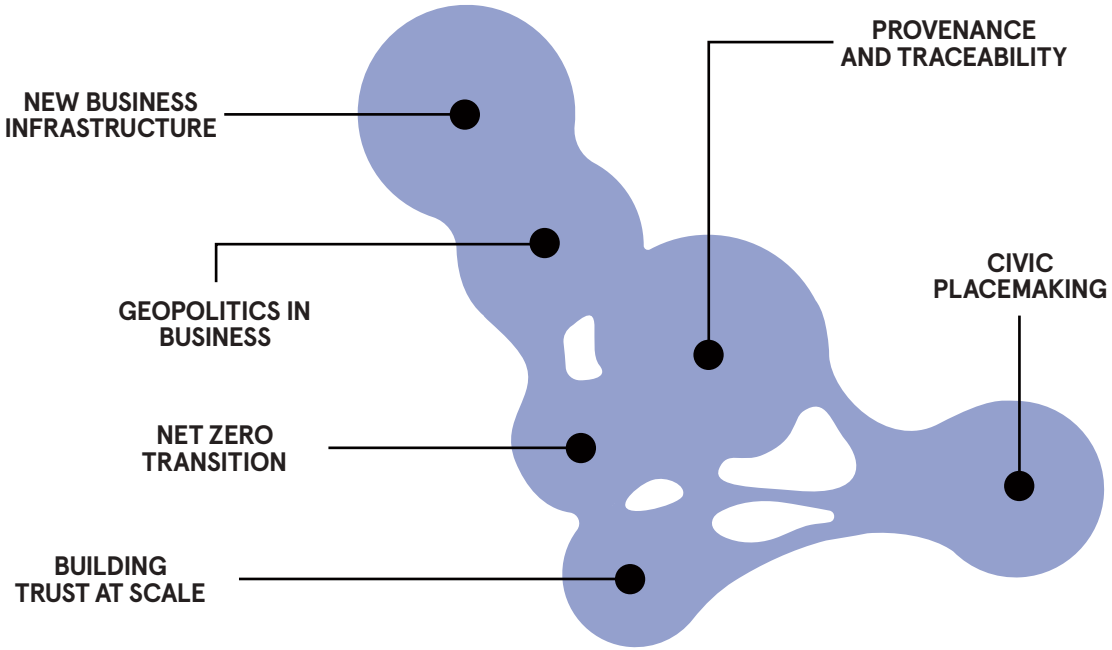
Sofia Hernandez
Global Head of Business Marketing & Commercial Partnerships, TikTok

"Arbitraging trust will become a very interesting new currency in this post-trust environment where you don't trust anyone."

Laszlo Peter
CEO, OriginsNext



BLOB 2 SOLVING PROBLEMS OF SCALE



less competent compared to the wider population. This is how social contracts crumble. When people and communities see businesses as "the other", extracting rather than adding value, your foundation starts to crack.

Understandably, many leaders worry about their business's social license to operate, but there is some good news: people want you to show up. 71% of Edelman respondents want leaders to take action on societal issues—to act responsibly. 82% point to listening and dialogue as ways to build trust. The math backs this up. Kantar (2020) data shows that responsibility is the largest contributor to a business's reputation (at 49%), ahead of leadership (32%) or success (11%).

Genuine engagement creates genuine trust. Leaders who invest in civic placemaking—engaging with communities, finding real points of interaction, and co-designing solutions—see the results. External trust isn't just good for business—it forms its foundation.

PROVE IT WITH PROVENANCE

Trust manifests practically through accountability. Today, accountability stretches beyond your organisation to encompass your entire value system, often globally. The drivers? The three Rs: regulation, risk, and responsibility.

Regulation pushes accountability deeper into your supply chain. You'll soon need to report not just on your direct carbon emissions, but also the indirect upstream and downstream ones. These Scope 3 emissions represent 70% of an average corporate carbon footprint (Bloomberg 2023). The same scrutiny applies to your impact on deforestation, biodiversity, and the broader environment.

Risk exposure is climbing. Geopolitical conflicts, new tariffs, and extreme weather events are multiplying disruptions. Your board, investors, regulators, and key partners now demand transparency on critical dependencies for planning and oversight.

Then there's *responsibility*: human rights, labour standards, Indigenous community rights, modern slavery prevention, and product safety through secure sourcing practices.

Earning trust takes accountability. And a key part of that is provenance data, which traces the origins of products and services at the system level. Most businesses will need to assemble networks of reliable partners to create such data capabilities.

TRUST IN A TIME OF TENSIONS

The global landscape has shifted beneath your feet. Global peace is at its lowest since WWII, with a record-high 59 active state-based conflicts (Global Peace Index 2025). Meanwhile, global military spending rose for the 10th consecutive year, to $2.7bn, in 2024 (SIPRI 2025).

The skills in this Blob

+ BUILDING TRUST AT SCALE

The ability to engage with government and policy; communicate effectively in complex public environments; and maintain legitimacy and social license to operate. Proficiency in data-based measures to build trust and influence stakeholders.

+ CIVIC PLACEMAKING

Understanding your role in the broader civic ecosystem. The ability to effectively engage, and co-design, with external stakeholders and local communities; build and maintain products and services that resonate, for positive outcomes.

+ GEOPOLITICS IN BUSINESS

The ability to understand and interpret geopolitical developments through a business lens; make sense of policy moves by nation states; and assess the long-term implications of short-term geopolitical events and global crises.

+ NET ZERO TRANSITION

Understanding the strategic risk implications, reporting requirements, and frameworks for setting and managing decarbonisation goals in guiding your organisation's transition to net zero carbon emissions.

+ PROVENANCE AND TRACEABILITY

Comprehension of regulatory requirements and business cases necessitating the establishment of provenance and traceability. The ability to navigate complexities of accounting in multistakeholder ecosystems; and building trust and assurance for automatic data capture, secure storage, and transmission.

+ NEW BUSINESS INFRASTRUCTURE

Understanding the dependencies between cyber-physical systems, data centres, and evolving energy generation, storage, and distribution, which increasingly shape economic activity, and drive cost and strategic business impact.

This upheaval hits your bottom line directly. Large companies (3,500 global companies with $1bn+ revenue) lost a combined $350bn in profit due to "geopolitical and macro volatility", according to EY-Parthenon (FT 2025a). Global trade, however, reached a record $33tr in 2024 (UN 2025). Rising trade amid rising tensions: the contradiction defining today's business environment.

When old stabilities go missing, trust must fill the gap. But trust without understanding is just hope. You need to grasp how geopolitical developments translate into commercial consequences—not just to react to shocks, but to assess them and manage external dependencies.

NEW DEPENDENCIES, NEW DECISIONS

Your business increasingly runs on infrastructure you don't own, can't see, and might not fully understand.

The backbone of today's economy has shifted from physical assets you could visit—roads, factories, warehouses—to digital infrastructure: data centres, cloud networks, and algorithmic systems that power everything from customer interactions to supply chains.

This shift creates entirely new trust decisions. Without access to data centres, scaling any modern business is impossible. The economy now lives in data centres. As such, the sector is expanding rapidly. And it's intimately linked to energy. As AI adoption accelerates, energy demand is skyrocketing. But the energy system itself is in transition. And businesses are no longer just consumers but active participants. You might be investing in renewable generation, battery storage, or even selling energy back to the grid.

This new economic infrastructure comes with new dependencies and opportunities. What used to be simple infrastructure choices now directly impacts your cost base, risk profile, compliance, and reputation. As you scale your capabilities, trust replaces control. Do you know enough to trust your own decisions?

+ Solving problems of scale, in numbers

STEAL THIS
Click to steal

TRUST IN LEADERS DECREASES

68%

of people say business leaders "purposely mislead people", up 12 points since 2021 (Edelman 2025)

RESPONSIBILITY PAYS OFF

Responsibility is the top driver of corporate reputation (Kantar 2020)

TRUST DRIVES BUSINESS

91%

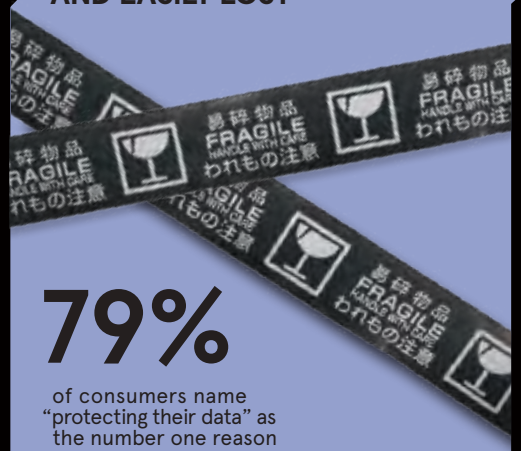
of executives see a direct link between trust and the bottom line (PwC 2023)

PROVENANCE BUILDS TRUST

9.7%

mark-up on what shoppers would pay for products that can prove sustainable origins (Shopify 2025)

TRUST IS FRAGILE AND EASILY LOST



79%

of consumers name "protecting their data" as the number one reason they trust an organisation (PwC 2023)

NEW DEPENDENCIES REQUIRE TRUST

90%

of AI data centres that organisations rely on are operated by US or Chinese companies (NYT 2025)

THE COST OF INSTABILITY

$350BN

Profit lost by 3,500 large global companies in 2024, due to "geopolitical and macro volatility" (FT 2025)

GLOBAL TRADE IS ALIVE AND WELL

2/3

of companies worldwide plan to maintain or expand business with China in 2025 (QIMA 2025)

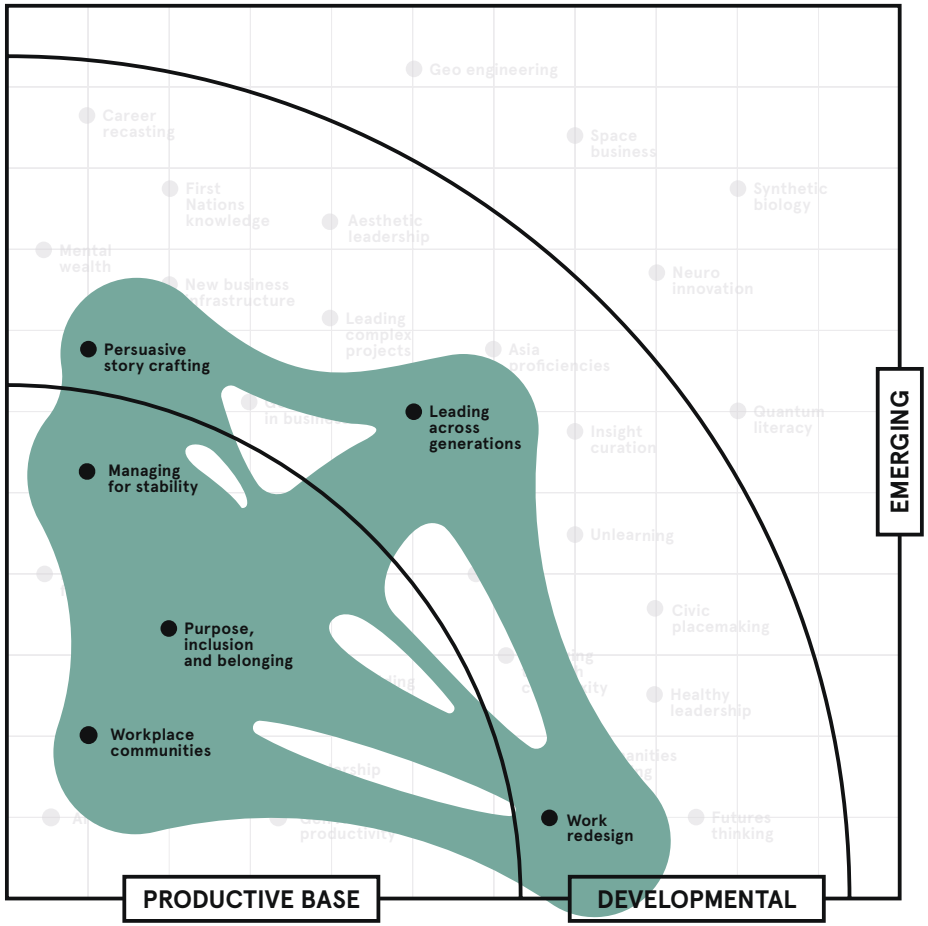
“The pace and rate of change is going to increase exponentially. We must increase our comfort with change and ambiguity because it’s ever present. You must still provide people with a sense of confidence and stability.”

Kiersten Robinson
Chief People Officer, Commonwealth Bank

BLOB 3

Working across difference

You need to change for stability



In this decade of disorientation, where everything seems to change all the time, where do your people and teams find orientation? Where do they find the steadiness to work effectively? You need to balance change and the need to adapt with finding common ground and a clear direction.

It's not so much the pace of change but its scope that drives complexity. AI requires a rethink of how work gets done. Diversity calls for inclusion and belonging. Shifting generational values and individual expectations must be balanced with the needs of the team and the collective. Big picture uncertainties add extra pressures to this already tricky tightrope walk.

As change continues to charge on, it's time to focus on stability. Lead with purpose, articulate clear narratives, craft productive work communities and tech-enabled team practices. People don't want more change. Be a source of stability for your teams, even though that same stability isn't afforded to you as a leader.

MIND YOUR CHANGE

Your people are already drowning in change; 69% of people believe society is changing too quickly (Edelman 2024), 64% of professionals feel overwhelmed by workplace change (LinkedIn 2024), and change fatigue now ranks as HR leaders' second-biggest barrier to successful initiatives (Gallagher 2025).

"We need to genuinely remove the fear of change, so our people stop talking about being hit by waves of change and learn how to surf it and love it."

Michelle Bagnall
CEO, Bank First

"Times are uncertain, but your people want you to be really certain about the decisions that you give them. Storytelling helps you shepherd them through uncertainty."

Emily Craven
CEO, Story City

"How do you change course and take all those people with you? You've got to connect with a broader purpose, communicate well, and listen to the system."

Seckin Ungur
Partner, Dean of Executive Leadership Program, McKinsey

"A team will never function efficiently unless every person in it has the psychological safety to contribute and to step up when necessary and call 'STOP!'"

Richard de Crespigny AM
Captain and former Qantas A380 pilot

"Leaders need to take their people with them. We are not always good at this. Show empathy, take the time to understand how people feel, build trust and connection to have effective conversations. There's no point being a leader who frightens people."

Jane Spring AM
Chair, Australia's Disability Strategy Advisory Council

"My job as CEO is not star player, it's head coach. I need to listen to my people, watch what's going on around me, out there in the real world, and get the obstacles out of the way of our people doing their best work."

Steve Vamos
Former CEO, Xero

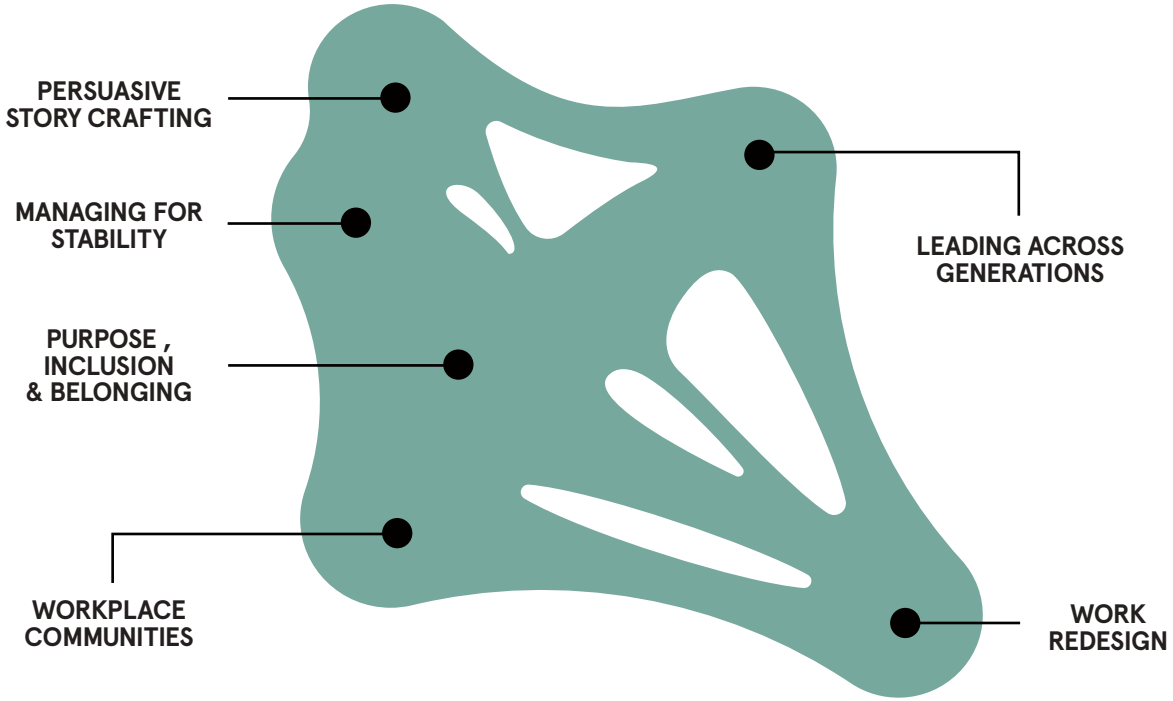
"Getting the best out of people has become harder for leaders because working from home whilst improving flexibility can limit that human connection with your team. It's a real mindset shift managing hybrid employees. It's important to set boundaries and drive people to outcomes versus actual time in the office."

Paul Zahra
Non-Executive Director &
Former CEO, Australian Retailers Association

"When a leader tries to make it as convenient as possible for their employees, then people often stop moving. When everything is how I like it, I stop moving, keep everything the same. A little discomfort is often helpful, to require movement, to stimulate improvement and growth."

Tino Kuehnel
CEO, byte – Bayerische Agentur für Digitales

BLOB 3 WORKING ACROSS DIFFERENCE



Change fatigue isn't just exhaustion—it's linked to apathy, stress, and burnout (Day et al. 2017). And here's what's concerning: often it's self-inflicted by organisations themselves.

Researchers have identified "defensive organising" as a big contributor. This involves launching change initiatives mainly to alleviate your own anxiety rather than serve a clear strategic purpose (AMJ 2024). These projects usually fail spectacularly, ending in exhaustion and resentment, and taking down the leader. Don't be one of those leaders.

As change in response to external disorientation and technological disruption peaks, you want to save transformation for where it's necessary. Hybrid work? Yes. AI transformation? Definitely. But reorganising just to appear decisive? Think twice.

In today's environment, it takes more poise and courage to sit with the anxiety and hold a steady course with measured change, rather than launch a broad initiative. Don't confuse being seen to do *something* with doing the right thing. It's a fine line between necessary transformation and defensive organising but your teams will notice the difference.

DIVERSITY, DIVERSIFIED

Diversity has been on your radar for years. But lately it's showing up in novel ways. The dimensions of difference in today's workplaces are as varied as they are numerous. And some of the biggest shifts are happening where you least expect them.

Take generational and gender differences. Globally, young women have grown vastly more progressive than young men over the past decade. Young women are now 27 percentage points more progressive than conservative, while young men are split equally (Economist 2024). The gap is largest in the US, smaller in Australia, but it's real everywhere. What's more: young men are now less progressive on gender issues than older men, a highly unusual generational finding.

These attitudes are grounded more in economic reality than cultural change, with many young men feeling their struggles aren't being recognised (Lowy Institute 2025). Yet diversity expectations are highest among younger employees: 63% of Gen Z expect their workplace to promote inclusivity, and 53% would quit if diversity efforts were lacking (EHL Business School 2025).

Working across difference is a delicate balancing act. You must develop skills to use difference productively while fostering belonging and shared purpose. Belonging creates stability. It's associated with a 56% increase in job performance and 50% reduction in turnover (BetterUp 2019). Diversity without belonging is just a collection of individuals. For best results, you need both diversity *and* belonging.

The skills in this Blob

+ MANAGING FOR STABILITY

The ability to absorb the pressures of continuous transformation—shielding your teams so they can work productively—by articulating direction, creating routines as anchors of certainty, and providing psychological safety to fail.

+ PURPOSE, INCLUSION & BELONGING

The ability to articulate and embody organisational purpose and values, and leverage diversity in all its forms. Promoting inclusivity, along with a culture where individuals feel a sense of belonging and motivation to contribute.

+ PRODUCTIVE WORK COMMUNITIES

The ability to cultivate productive teams across all modes of work: physical, remote, and hybrid. Balancing individual flexibility and collective requirements of work coordination, fairness, and inclusivity.

+ PERSUASIVE STORY CRAFTING

The ability to develop compelling narratives that engage, persuade, and inspire audiences. Leveraging data, insights, and rhetorical techniques to communicate complex ideas, evoke emotions, influence stakeholders, and drive action.

+ WORK REDESIGN

The ability to analyse and recast dependencies between tasks and roles, accounting for the impact of emerging technology (e.g. AI). Balancing automation and human expertise, individual roles and systemic outcomes.

+ LEADING ACROSS GENERATIONS

The ability to navigate the complexities of a multi-generational workforce with diverse expectations, communication styles and work preferences. Fostering understanding, productive collaboration and knowledge sharing.

GREAT FLEXPECTATIONS

Work is everywhere now: hybrid, flexible, freelance. You're caught between people's flexibility expectations and the need for policies that work for your teams and collective. Hybrid means some want to work in the office, others from anywhere. Freelancing adds another layer still.

By 2027, the total share of freelancers globally is tipped to grow to 40%, with the US hitting more than 50%. Already, 53% of Gen Z work full-time hours in freelance roles for greater autonomy and control, and 36% of knowledge workers are considering the switch (Upwork 2025). Your teams will include more externals than ever—people who want your work but not your job, or to be a leader.

Then, as is so often the case these days, there's AI. People are using it differently: some embrace it, others resist, most are somewhere in between. Your job is to channel individual AI productivity into team effectiveness. Welcome to what we call "tech-enabled teams": people working anywhere, using collaborative tech, integrating AI.

ON BALANCE

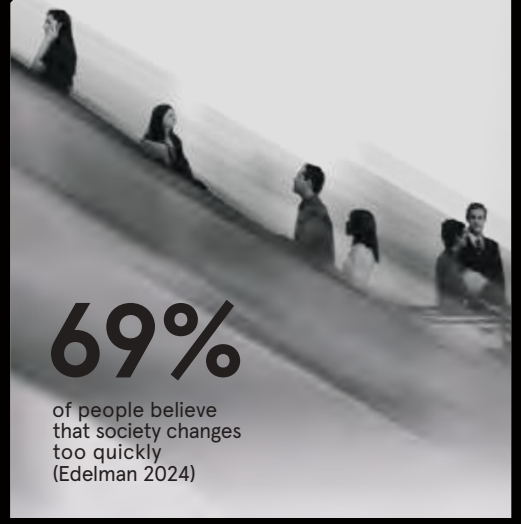
You're managing a paradox. Your people need stability, but the world demands flexibility. The answer isn't in choosing one but in balancing both.

Stability in changing times comes from responsiveness, not structure. Already, 71% of employees say their job description no longer matches what they actually do (HBR 2024). Instead of reorganising frequently, build adaptive, skills-based work systems that can flex with changing needs through upskilling, while also maintaining clarity about outcomes.

+ Working across difference, in numbers

STEAL THIS
Click to steal

CHANGE IN SOCIETY IS TOO FAST



69%

of people believe that society changes too quickly (Edelman 2024)

CHANGE IS ON THE RISE

85%

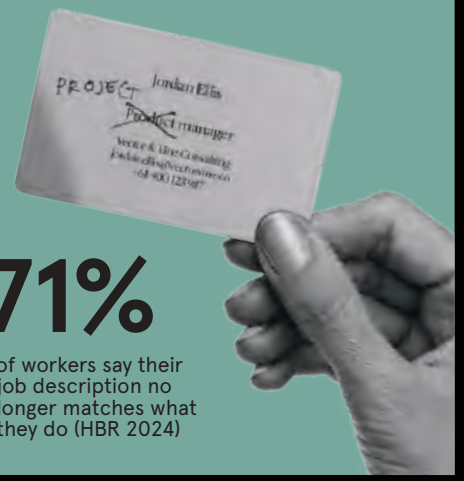
of executives and project managers see a rise in change initiatives (Pollack 2025)

PACE OF CHANGE IS STRESSFUL

68%

of professionals are seeking support because change is overwhelming (LinkedIn 2024)

WORKERS' WORK IS CHANGING



71%

of workers say their job description no longer matches what they do (HBR 2024)

WORKERS DISENGAGE

21%

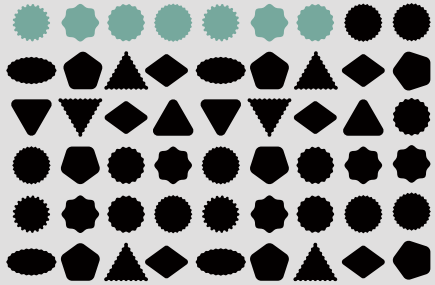
of global employees are 'engaged' at work (best practice orgs are at 70%) (Gallup 2025)

HYBRID REMAINS IMPORTANT

88%

of Australians prefer to work from home at least some of the time (HILDA 2025)

DIVERSITY IS EFFECTIVE



87%

The likelihood of diverse teams making a good decision (CIPD UK 2023)

INCLUSION IS EXPECTED

of Gen Zs expect their workplace to promote inclusivity (EHL Hospitality Business School 2025)

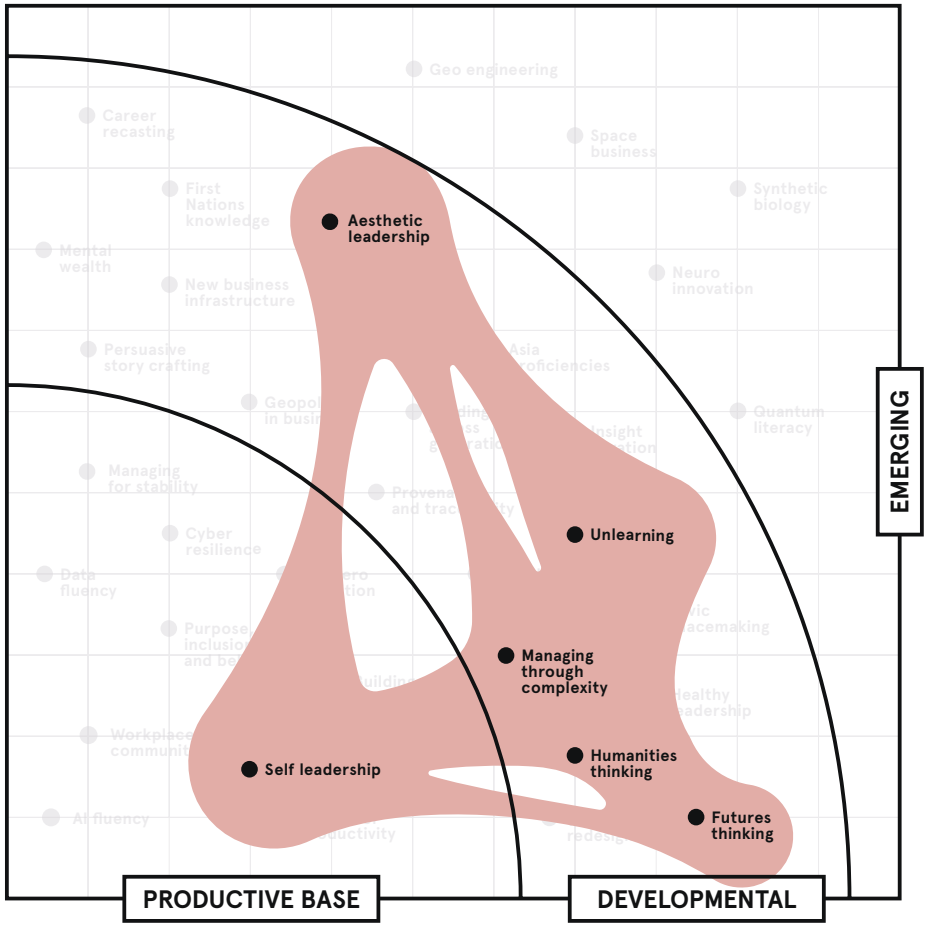
"The leader of the future needs to be able to handle ambiguity and nuance, while still maintaining strategic clarity. Situational ambiguity and strategic clarity need to coexist. In an uncertain world—leaders will need to bring strategic clarity to what you are currently doing—and reinterpret that strategy should the operating environment change."

David Thodey AO, FTSE
Chancellor, The University of Sydney

BLOB 4

Thinking through complexity

You need to do less, with more



Information is abundant, but your attention isn't. Online content is less reliable, connectivity is constant, your contexts keep multiplying. You simply cannot engage with, process, or do *everything*.

You need to do less, with more care, and greater discernment. You need to cultivate your own position. You need to lead with *taste*. Taste isn't merely about personal preference, but respect for your audiences. When your "no" flows from clear conviction rather than arbitrary choice, your elegant refusal will be understood and appreciated. This is leadership through curation, not accumulation.

As stakeholder demands proliferate, you must navigate contexts authentically while making yourself relevant in each. For the bigger picture, develop foresight, preparedness for possible futures, and a sense of direction without the trap of prediction—yet with a willingness to unlearn what no longer works.

TOO MUCH INFORMATION

From the beginning of the computer age, we've used technology to improve information supply. Today, we've vastly overshot. Workers are reportedly wasting 3 hours and 27 minutes per week dealing with information overload, often self-inflicted by organisations through duplicate or inconsistent messaging (HBR 2023). They're also interrupted every two minutes by incoming emails or messages.

"That idea of working through things yourself, working through problems, trying to get to some kind of truth… that's obviously a very hard thing to do in today's society."

Nathan Birch
Former CEO, Interbrand ANZ

"I need to reduce noise, and I need to get the balance right between being busy, being open to new ideas, and navigating through. It's a muscle I've being building for a long time."

Jacqui Feeney
CEO, Screen Queensland

"To be well informed, leaders need trusted peer groups, information alliances."

Heather Domin
Vice President and Head of Office of Responsible AI and Governance, HCLTech

"Onboarding foresight in decision-making is critical for leaders."

Kristel Van der Elst
Director General,
Policy Horizons Canada

"We are no longer able to show up as executives and representatives of the company and separate the personal from the professional. Leaders need to find a new balance."

Sofia Hernandez
Global Head of Business Marketing & Commercial Partnerships, TikTok

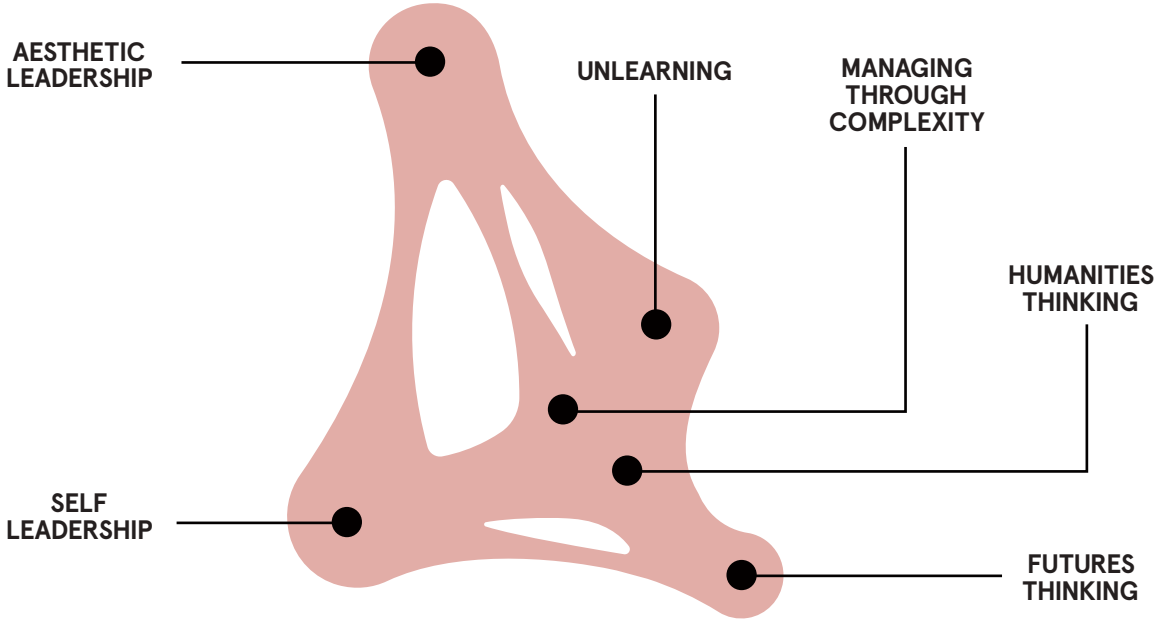
"Leaders need to have taste. We often think of taste as pretentiousness. It gets a bad rap. But to have taste means to give a sh*t, having spent time caring deeply about things, having context."

Matt Klein
Head of Global Foresight, Reddit

"Leaders need to be excellent communicators, both in receiving information, distilling it and importantly explaining the 'why'. I think workers are much less inclined to accept something just because someone with a big job title said it. They want to know the context for decisions and expect to be brought along."

Matthew Saxon
Chief People Officer, Zoom

BLOB 4 THINKING THROUGH COMPLEXITY



Where employees suffer, leaders fare worse. More than half of leaders say their work feels chaotic and fragmented (Microsoft 2025). As a leader you're not just coping with your own information burden, you're the primary target for everyone else's. The very connectivity tools that enable leadership also ensure you're never truly untethered from the avalanche. Technology is now at the heart of information overload, with terms like "technostress" and "hyperconnectivity" entering the vernacular.

MOMENTS OF TRUTH

You still need to know what's going on. Yet the information environment has shifted around you. Invisible algorithms curate your information feed, content is AI-generated, and a considerable amount is of dubious quality; slop has started to permeate the places you seek out information.

Traditional cues for credibility no longer work. Research shows that humans consistently fail to distinguish between AI-created and human-created content (PNAS 2023). The boundaries of what constitutes news have blurred, leaving people struggling to identify legitimate sources (Pew 2025). Meanwhile, fake news travels 10-times faster than regular news on social media and is 70% more likely to be re-shared (Science 2018).

The scale and impact of the content deluge is well-known, what to do about it less so. Automation gets you more with less, but value actually comes from less with more: less volume, more relevance, and more accuracy. Many leaders tell us they're looking for human solutions, such as circles of reliable sources and info networks they can trust. They're also highly selective about what they read.

TASTE'S GOOD

At the heart of good choices—about what to read, what's relevant, and what deserves your attention—is taste. It requires conviction, a coherent point of view, and the ability to articulate why a decision is 'good' and 'right'. In a decade of disorientation, there's no optimal choice known in advance, only commitments to a course of action.

Taste can be developed. It's personal, but it's not arbitrary. Others recognise and respond to it. Good taste is grounded in empathy and being genuinely attuned to your audiences. It requires both immersion in the world around you and the ability to step back and reflect. It requires making mistakes, learning, and refining your understanding.

But the best leaders don't just have taste. They help shape it. They participate in defining what good looks like in their industry, their organisation, their social circles. When your decisions are consistent, confident, and backed by conviction, they inspire and instil motivation in others. They let people know what the standard is. And they paint a clear picture of who you are and what you're about.

Cultivating taste allows you to make choices that are both authentic to you and resonant with your audiences.

The skills in this Blob

+ SELF-LEADERSHIP

The ability to manage your attention in the face of hyper-connectivity and information abundance; prioritise tasks; curate insights; and maintain focus to build resilience and navigate the complexities of the modern workplace.

+ HUMANITIES THINKING

The ability to engage techniques such as interpretation, sense-making, and imagination to navigate uncertainty; learn from history; and craft compelling narratives, using analogies and metaphors to communicate effectively.

+ MANAGING THROUGH COMPLEXITY

Learn to unpack complex phenomena without resorting to reductionism; address root causes and deep cultural drivers of problems; navigate competing expectations; and bring stakeholders along on issues without clear solutions.

+ UNLEARNING

The ability to use surprise and intractable problems as opportunities to uncover and challenge tacit and non-obvious assumptions. Develop a willingness and ability to change your mind and let go of established concepts that no longer serve you.

+ FUTURES THINKING

The ability to craft and envision multiple possible futures, considering emerging trends, potential disruptions, and long-term consequences of present-day actions. Become proficient in scenario analysis, strategic foresight, and signals methods.

+ AESTHETIC LEADERSHIP

The ability to relate to and act in different contexts and media; to project yourself and communicate, to judge and translate your preferences into good choices across different contexts, without fracturing the coherence of your persona.

BE YOURSELF. EVERYWHERE.

Contexts have multiplied. Internal teams, external partners, public forums, policymakers, local communities, global stakeholders. Each needs a nuanced approach, specific language, targeted emphasis. The whiplash is real.

You're caught between global complexity and local engagement, between corporate messaging and authentic voice. How do you maintain authenticity when compliance demands moderation? How do you blend professional personas with your personal self? How do you avoid losing yourself while adapting to each audience?

You must navigate contextually, and aesthetically. Adapt your delivery, not your conviction. And practice. Paralysis kills authenticity faster than imperfection. You can't be everything to everyone, but you *can* be yourself in ways your various audiences recognise and respect.

THE FUTURE TODAY

In disorienting times, the future gains new relevance. Not as something you predict and plan for, but as what orients you in the present. Working with possible futures provides big picture direction without the false promise of certainty.

Futures thinking prioritises intellectual flexibility rather than rigid plans. It creates responsiveness and preparedness. When considering different pathways, this style of thinking means you're less surprised by change and quicker to adapt.

Futures thinking requires an openness to your environment—to pick up on small cues and use surprises as moments for sense-making. It helps you to learn, but also to unlearn, by letting go of approaches that no longer serve you and assumptions that limit your thinking.

Your relationship with the future will shape your decisions today.

+ Thinking through complexity, in numbers

MESSAGE OVERLOAD IS REAL

270

Average number of daily messages (Email and Teams) received in a work day (Microsoft 2025)

WE'RE ALWAYS INTERRUPTED

275

Average number of daily interruptions for workers (Microsoft 2025)

INFO OVERLOAD IS COSTLY

3.5 HRS

Average time per week wasted by workers due to information overload (HBR 2023)

INFORMED BY SOCIAL MEDIA

54%

Percentage of US users who get their news on social platforms (BBC 2025b)

INFORMED BY AI OVERVIEWS

30–70%

Drop in click-through to actual web sources from AI overviews (BBC 2025c)

UNRELIABLE AI NEWS SUMMARIES

51%

Percentage of AI news summaries with significant issues (BBC 2025a)

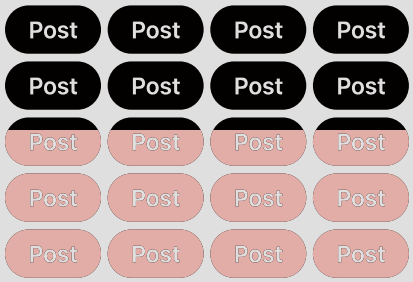
DROWNING IN SLOP

*AI-generated image (obviously)

717%

Increase in detections of dedicated AI slop sites (Digiday 2025)

LINKEDIN NOISE INCREASES



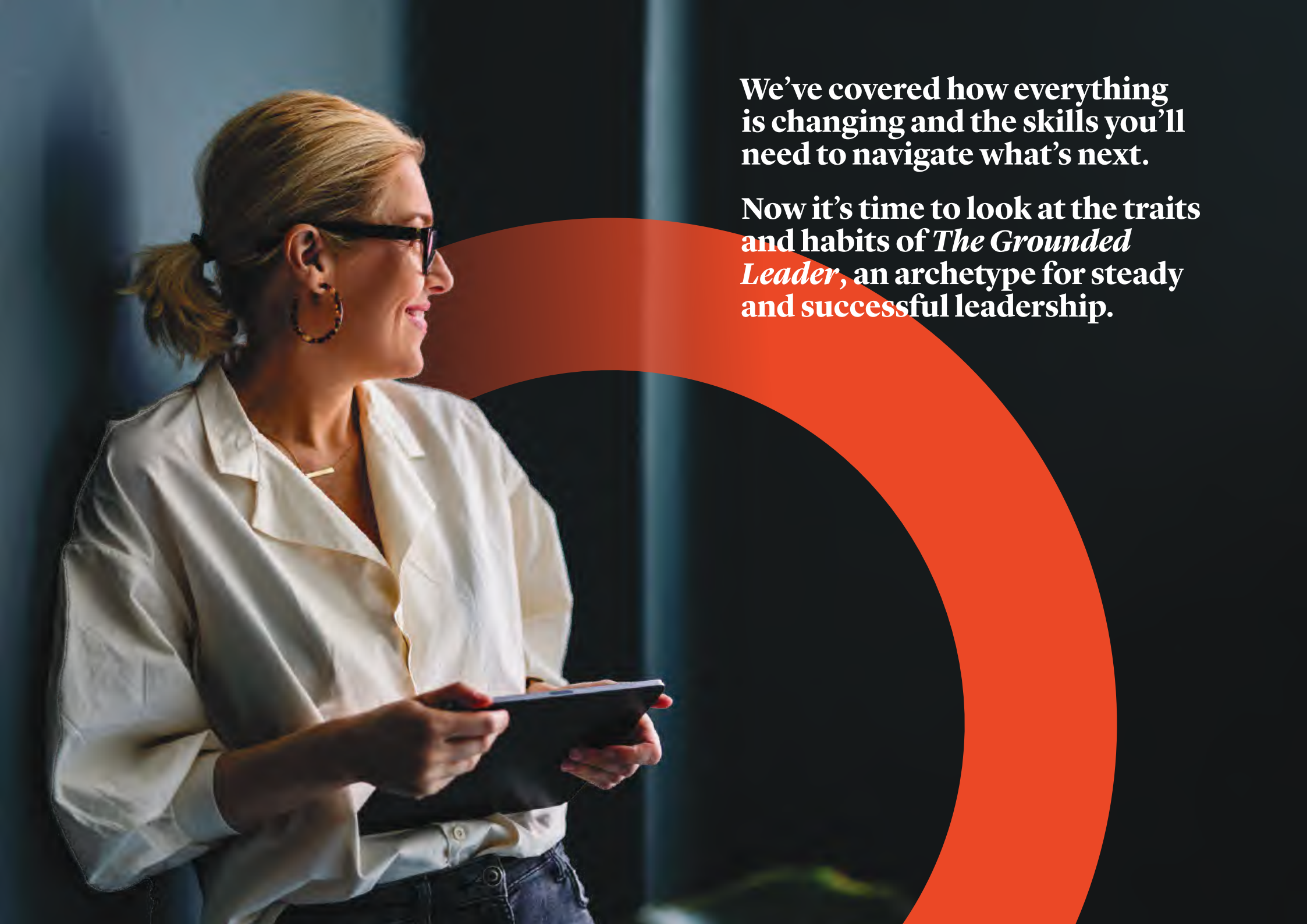
54%

of longer form English language LinkedIn posts are now AI-generated (Wired 2025)

NO TIME TO LISTEN

31%

Percentage of US users aged 18-29 who speed up podcast playback (Economist 2025a)



We've covered how everything is changing and the skills you'll need to navigate what's next.

Now it's time to look at the traits and habits of *The Grounded Leader*, an archetype for steady and successful leadership.

The Grounded Leader

In a disorienting world of Shifts, Clashes, and ambient uncertainty, your people will look to you for perspective and direction. In 2026, it's The Grounded Leader who'll be best positioned to engage, guide, and inspire the team.

01 GROUNDED LEADERS CULTIVATE TASTE

As a leader, people seek your perspective on a range of topics, so taste is essential. Grounded Leaders immerse themselves in the world, engage with passionate people who care and think differently to them, and they make time to reflect on their experiences.

Develop the habit of being inquisitive and intellectually omnivorous, curating your news diet so it has nutritional value, sitting with the material you've consumed, and developing your own, discerning point of view.

02 GROUNDED LEADERS MAKE SENSE

In the decade of disorientation, you not only handle ambiguity while striving for clarity but also play the role of translator for your diverse stakeholders—turning messy info and ideas into messages that make sense.

Develop the habit of protecting your focus by filtering out the noise as best you can. For this, build tech literacy to understand the algorithms in your life and make them work for you.

03 GROUNDED LEADERS SPEAK HUMAN

Whether you're in the tearoom or the boardroom, you know that *how* you say things is just as important as *what* you say. Grounded Leaders keep it real, give their words a pulse, and recognise that a little personality goes a long way.

Develop the habit of talking in everyday language: frank and jargon-free, with empathy and respect for your audiences. For best results, infuse that with humour and personal anecdotes where appropriate.

04 GROUNDED LEADERS ARE PLACEMAKERS

Your day-to-day might be turbulent but you work hard to create stability for your organisation. Specifically, a place of psychological safety and productive community where people can speak up, connect, and collaborate at their best.

Develop the habit of thinking from the front but leading from the middle: inviting and listening to opinions, building trust through relationships, and giving people space to make their own decisions.

05 GROUNDED LEADERS ARE LIFELONG LEARNERS

The more you know, the less daunting Shifts, Clashes, and ambient uncertainty become. Don't rest on your experience alone—every day presents an opportunity to learn.

Develop the habit of attempting hard things, experimenting, and making mistakes (and acknowledging them). Be open to new people and new ideas. And don't be afraid to change your mind. As Daniel Kahneman once said: "Let's hope that there are better ideas that come up and capture the imagination of people."

"You need people who have both got the breadth of understanding and the curiosity to learn about what's going on in the world, but also the focus to be able to discern what really matters versus what is just sort of cocktail party conversations."

Ian Narev
CEO & MD, SEEK

"The challenge for a leader is making time to do the thinking and the reading about the bigger picture, which often coincides with medium to long term."

The Hon. Andrew Bell
Chief Justice of NSW

"Data might inform you of bad choices, but it won't tell you the right choice. You can use data to prune the decision tree, to tell you which choices to eliminate, but it won't tell you which one to choose. For that you have to use judgement."

Dan Clancy
CEO, Twitch

"If there's one thing you would want your leadership to be, it's self-aware and applying the right mindset to the situation you face."

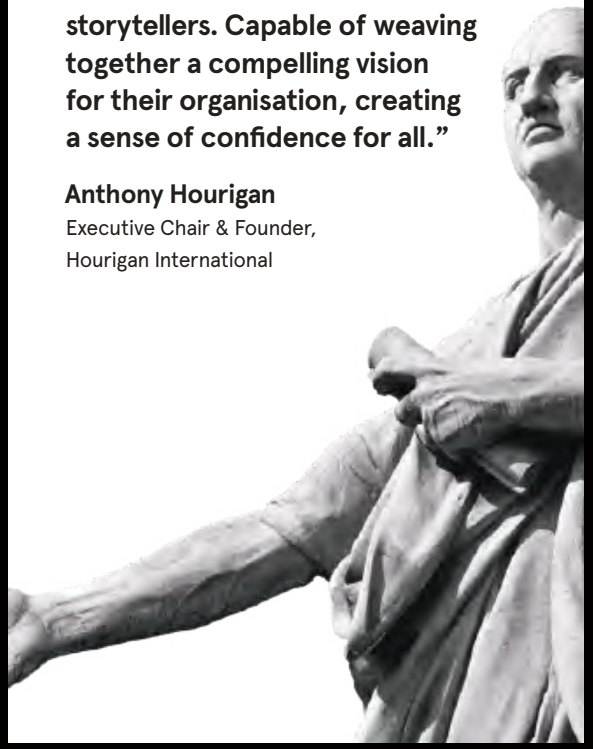
Steve Vamos
Former CEO, Xero

"Leaders need taste, a sense of perspective, the ability to curate, judge and bring an opinion from a place of self-reflection."

Matt Klein
Head of Global Foresight, Reddit

"Leaders of the future need to be modern Renaissance people, with a broad knowledge including the humanities. Powerful communicators and storytellers. Capable of weaving together a compelling vision for their organisation, creating a sense of confidence for all."

Anthony Hourigan
Executive Chair & Founder, Hourigan International



"Humans get better through hardship, humans improve their craft through friction."

Rafael Sang
Founder & CEO, MoM Creative Agency

"Shared humour is the ultimate humanity. To share a joke with someone, to be laughing about our own humanity is part of good leadership."

Jane Spring AM
Chair, Australia's Disability Strategy Advisory Council

"You need humility and vulnerability, knowing that the minute you think you know everything is a second before you make a really dumb mistake."

Richard de Crespigny AM
Captain and former Qantas A380 pilot

"There's an element of leadership where vulnerability is needed and without over-sharing."

Susan Pearce AM
Secretary, NSW Health

"I would gift the power of storytelling to every leader that I ever meet."

Dom Price
Former Work Futurist, Atlassian

"Sitting with other human beings, in a space together, taking an imaginative leap—there's such potency and power in that."

Kip Williams
Former Artistic Director, Sydney Theatre Company

"You have to keep looking for your critics and bring them in to disagree with you, rather than avoid them. It's dramatically easier for them to see the flaws in your ideas than for you to, so that's the best way to make true progress on your ideas."

Saul Perlmutter
Nobel Prize-winning astrophysicist

"You've got to be learning all the time, because if you're not learning, you'll be going backwards relative to the world changing so fast."

Vicki Brady
CEO, Telstra

"Are you a learn-it-all even after you are a know-it-all? Even in an area where you are an expert, are you willing to continue to grow, take in new information, to change your mind?"

Nickle LaMoreaux
Chief Human Resources Officer, IBM

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